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INSIDE



Airport attacks claim three lives in Saudi Arabia

CAIRO
Three people were killed in attacks on two airports in Saudi Arabia, Riyadh said on Wednesday. It did not blame any party for the attacks, but Houthis in Yemen claimed earlier in the day that they carried out attacks against the two airports. » PAGE 14



60 cases of abuse of boys reported from Telangana

HYDERABAD
Data shared by Women Safety Wing of the Telangana Police show a rise in the number of boys recorded as victims under the POCSO Act. Four male child victims were recorded in 2024. The number rose to 61 in 2025, and to 62 from January to September 2026. » PAGE 3



Russian strikes leave 15 people dead in Ukraine

KYIV
Russia pounded Ukraine with waves of missiles and drones on Wednesday, killing at least 15 people, Ukrainian officials said. One missile hit an apartment block in the city of Pryluky, killing at least nine people. » PAGE 14

Protests will go on until CEC resigns: Rahul

Several Opposition leaders detained for second day in a row while moving towards Jantar Mantar | Opposition leaders stage dharna near designated protest site; SP leaders absent from the protests | They are beating MPs; their policemen scratched me all over, Congress's Priyanka Vadra alleges

Sandeep Phukan
NEW DELHI

The protests against Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar will not stop until he resigns over alleged vote *chori* (theft), Leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha Rahul Gandhi said on Wednesday, after the Delhi Police detained him and other Opposition leaders for the second day in a row while they were on their way to Jantar Mantar for a dharna. Mr. Gandhi, who has stressed a “politics of resistance”, his sister Priyanka Gandhi Vadra, and other Opposition leaders staged an impromptu dharna at a roundabout barely a couple of hundred metres from Jantar Mantar, a designated protest site in central Delhi. “We are not going to stop protesting till [CEC] Gyanesh Kumar resigns. This is a fight to pro-



Leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha Rahul Gandhi during the INDIA bloc's protest demanding Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar's resignation in New Delhi on Wednesday. ANI

tect the most sacred thing in this country. There is nothing that [Prime Minister] Narendra Modi and [Union Home Minister] Amit Shah can do that will stop us,” Mr. Gandhi said. Samajwadi Party (SP)

members, however, were conspicuous by their absence. The Congress played it down, saying the invitation had been sent at short notice and some parties could not respond. Several other Opposi-

tion MPs, including CPI (M)'s John Brittas, CPI's P. Sandosh Kumar, Rashtriya Janata Dal's Manoj Jha, and Trinamool Congress's Derek O'Brien and Mahua Moitra were part of the protests. Telangana Chief

SC to examine plea on CEC appointment law

NEW DELHI
The Supreme Court on Wednesday agreed to examine and take a call on hearing an application seeking to recall a split verdict pronounced on September 23 in a case challenging the Election Commissioners' appointments law. The application questions why Justice Satish Chandra Sharma on the Bench did not reveal during proceedings that his son was a standing counsel for the Election Commission of India (ECI). » PAGE 5

Minister A. Revanth Reddy and his Kerala counterpart V.D. Satheesan were also part of the protests. There were dramatic scenes during the three-hour-long bus procession and the subsequent im-

promptu sit-in at the roundabout in front of the Le Meridien and Shangri-La hotels as the Opposition MPs were stopped by security personnel.

Carried on shoulders
Delhi Police personnel first forcibly removed Mr. Gandhi, carrying him on their shoulders, and put him inside a police van. “This is all panic reaction, this is all fear,” Mr. Gandhi said while sitting inside the van after his detention. As Congress workers punctured one of the van's tyres, it could travel only a short distance. Mr. Gandhi was taken to the Barakhamba Road police station and released by 8 p.m.

A visual of Ms. Vadra lying on her back on the street, clutching a copy of the Constitution, went viral on social media.

A large contingent of women police personnel then removed Ms. Vadra

and other women leaders who were lying on the road in protest.

“This is how they treat Members of Parliament who are asking simply to meet the Election Commissioners. This is how they treat us. They are beating Members of Parliament. Their policemen have scratched me all over,” Ms. Vadra alleged.

The police had stopped the buses carrying Opposition MPs, including Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge and general secretary (organisation) K.C. Venugopal, at the roundabout near the Le Meridien and Shangri-La hotels.

Leaders of the Indian National Developmental Inclusive Alliance (INDIA), however, are likely to continue with the protests on Thursday as well, top Congress leaders indicated.

YOUTH GROUPS' JOINT CALL
» PAGE 9

Crumble zone



Fragile structure: People gather in the New Seemapuri area of Delhi where a four-storey building collapsed on Wednesday. Three persons were killed and eight injured in the incident. PTI (REPORT: PAGE 4)

RBI raises repo rate to 5.5% amid 'calibrated tightening'

Lalatendu Mishra
MUMBAI

The Monetary Policy Committee (MPC) of the Reserve Bank of India (RBI) on Wednesday raised the policy repo rate under the liquidity adjustment facility (LAF) by 25 basis points to 5.50% and shifted its stance from neutral to calibrated tightening, signalling that rate cuts are off the table in the near term.

Consequently, the standing deposit facility (SDF) rate stands adjusted to 5.25%, and the marginal standing facility (MSF) rate and the bank rate to 5.75%.

The policy repo rate, which was cut to 5.25% in December 2025, had been kept on hold at the next four MPC meetings. In the easing cycle, the MPC had cut the rate by 125 basis points in phases, from 6.50% to 5.25%, before increasing it on Wednesday.

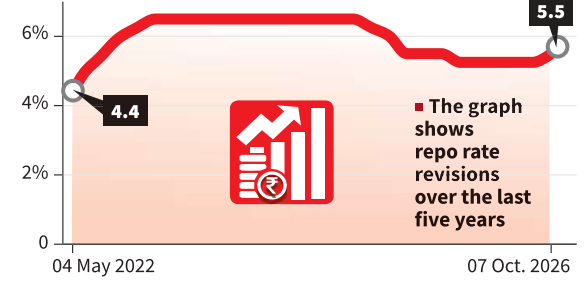
The sudden re-escalation of the West Asia conflict in September and the consequent hardening and volatility in global crude prices soured global economic sentiment and unsettled financial markets, RBI Governor Sanjay Malhotra said in a statement.

Further tightening of global financial conditions, uncertainty about fair valuation of AI stocks and an elusive resolution of the West Asia conflict pose significant downside risks to the global economic outlook, he highlighted in his statement.

“The duration and extent of the rate hike cycle would be contingent on the actual growth-inflation developments and outlook, especially that of underlying inflation, the extent of broadening of price pressures and second-round effects of the supply

Tighter grip

The shift in policy stance amid a sour global economic sentiment indicates that rate cuts are off the table in the near term, and policy action ahead can only be a rate hike or a pause



shock, as also the impact of demand impulses,” he emphasised. “Although global growth remains resilient, it is projected to decelerate in 2026 from the previous year. Driven by escalating energy costs and rising food prices, global inflation is projected to increase sharply prompting monetary policy tightening by major central banks,” he said. “Lingering trade uncertainty, rising bond yields in advanced economies and an appreciating dollar are keeping global financial market sentiments nervous and fragile,” he pointed out.

Why the MPC acted

On the rationale for the MPC's decision, the Governor said, “The MPC noted that the global context on account of geopolitical developments remains challenging. Nonetheless, the Indian economy has been strong, and the economic momentum remains broad-based. Moreover, the economy is expected to remain resilient.”

“It further observed that in light of available data, it is clear that inflation and its outlook are not benign as they were last year, with headline CPI (consumer price index) inflation ex-

pected to average almost 5.8% in the next three quarters and core inflation projected at 4.4% this financial year,” he said.

Looking ahead, global economic uncertainty and supply-chain disruptions are expected to have some bearing on domestic economic activity. Furthermore, a weak southwest monsoon along with strong El Niño conditions may affect the upcoming rabi season and rural demand, he stated.

“The likely resilient non-farm activity, however, will continue to support rural consumption. Sustained momentum in services, and broadly stable employment conditions are expected to sustain urban demand,” he said.

Real GDP growth for 2026-27 is projected at 7.1%. CPI inflation for 2026-27 is projected at 5.2%. Core inflation is projected at 4.4% for 2026-27.

On financial stability, he said the system-level financial parameters related to capital adequacy, liquidity, asset quality and profitability of scheduled commercial banks (SCBs) remained robust. Similarly, the system-level parameters of NBFCs were sound, he said.

Chemistry Nobel for French-Japanese duo who expanded 'mirrored' molecules study

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

French chemist Henri Kagan and Japanese chemist Kenso Soai were on Monday named the winners of the chemistry Nobel Prize for 2026 for their work showing how chemical reactions can amplify small asymmetries in molecules.

Their work centred on chiral molecules, which are molecules that can exist in two mirror-image forms, like a left and a right hand. Professor Kagan's work paved the way for scientists to tune chemical reactions to produce the desirable forms of drugs, agrochemicals, and fragrances. In 1986, Professor

Symmetric study

The duo's work is centred on molecules that can exist in two mirror-image forms, a property called chirality



Henri B. Kagan
Professor emeritus at the former Universite Paris-Sud, France



Kenso Soai
Professor emeritus at the Tokyo University of Science, Japan

■ Their study of chiral molecules expanded the understanding of why many molecules essential for life prefer just one of the two possible forms. The findings have been used to optimise chemical reactions as well

Kagan and his team made a landmark discovery involving catalysts – substances that influence reactions. They showed that a small imbalance in the ‘handedness’ of a catalyst could disproportionately bias the reaction's end products.

This finding was used to optimise chemical reactions.

Almost a decade on, Professor Soai and his colleagues showed that a chiral molecule could speed up the formation of other molecules with its own

handedness. His work expanded the understanding of why many molecules essential for life prefer just one of the two possible forms. The proteins in our bodies are made mostly of amino acids that have one of the two mirror-image arrangements.

The enzymes that catalyse chemical reactions in cells and the receptors that respond to chemical trigger signals are also chiral. As a result, the differently handed forms of a chiral drug can interact with these molecules to elicit varied responses, only one of which might be desirable. This was a challenge for chemists who had to manufacture the desirably handed form of a drug.

Former First Lady of Sri Lanka arrested

Meera Srinivasan
COLOMBO

Sri Lanka's anti-corruption body on Wednesday arrested former First Lady Shiranthi Rajapaksa, wife of former President Mahinda Rajapaksa, in connection with an investigation into alleged misuse of funds at her charity. She has been remanded until October 13. Her eldest son and Opposition lawmaker, Namal Rajapaksa, is also in remand custody after being arrested by the CIABOC last month over corruption allegations.

FULL REPORT ON
» PAGE 14

**DAY 2 OF
DETOUR**

High drama gripped Delhi again as an INDIA bloc lunch segued into a second day of protests led by Rahul Gandhi calling for the resignation of CEC Gyanesh Kumar



Congress leader Priyanka Gandhi Vadra; party workers and supporters atop a bus; Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge; and a protester being detained. ANI/REUTERS



INBRIEF

Digvijaya Singh set to launch M.P.-Ayodhya yatra on Oct. 20

Terming alleged “vote chori” and “chanda chori” as major issues confronting the nation, Congress veteran leader and former Madhya Pradesh Chief Minister Digvijaya Singh on Wednesday announced that he will embark on a yatra on October 20 to demand an impartial probe into them. Mr. Singh said his Satya Sanatan Swabhiman Yatra will start from Mahakal Temple in Ujjain, travel via Orchha in the central Madhya Pradesh and end at the Ram Temple in Ayodhya in adjoining Uttar Pradesh, covering a distance of around 850 km. The yatra will cover a distance of 15 km per day till it reaches its destination. PTI

Dharmendra Kashyap to quit BJP, announce next move soon

Former Uttar Pradesh Minister and Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) leader Dharmendra Kumar Kashyap on Wednesday said he will make a formal announcement about joining a new party after discussions with his supporters. His remarks came after he posted a picture of a sunset by the sea with the words “tata bye-bye” on Facebook, following the announcement of the BJP’s Rajya Sabha candidates for Uttar Pradesh, leading to speculation about his possible return to the Samajwadi Party. The Other Backwards Class leader was hopeful of securing a Rajya Sabha ticket but was not included in the list by the party, according to sources. Kashyap has not formally announced his resignation. PTI

SIR: special camps to restore names left out of Bengal rolls

State CEO puts up on website list of deletions under ASDD category; Mamata-led Trinamool faction MP Sagarika Ghose questions move after many people were denied right to vote

Shrabana Chatterjee
KOLKATA

Special camps will be held to ensure that any eligible voter whose name was deleted during the special intensive revision (SIR) under the absent, shifted, dead or duplicate (ASDD) category is put back on the electoral rolls through Form 6, Additional Chief Electoral Officer (CEO) of West Bengal Arindam Niyogi told *The Hindu* on Wednesday.

A few of these camps have already started operating in Hooghly’s Chanditala, Tarakeshwar, and Chandannagar, he added.

Over 58 lakh names, marked under the ASDD category, were left out of the draft roll published in December 2025.

The statement came a day after the CEO issued a notice stating that eligible



A special camp to accept Form 6 applications from new voters and those left out of the roll, in Hooghly. X/@CEOWESTBENGAL

voters left out of the voter list can apply for restoration of their name through Form 6. The notice also asked new voters in the State, any person above 18 years, to register and enroll their names in the voter list.

“For the left out eligible voter, the list of ASDD voters of SIR 2026 is available at the link ceowestbengal.wb.gov.in/asdsir and also at the respective links on

said.

Meanwhile, Mamata All India Trinamool Congress MP Sagarika Ghose criticised the move. “First, leave out LAKHS of eligible voters BEFORE the elections [2026 Assembly poll]. Ensure @BJP4India wins elections at all costs. Next, offer to add deleted voters AFTER the elections (after @BJP4India has won ILLEGALLY),” she wrote on X.

The CEO put up a post countering the claims and termed them “misleading”.

Former State CEO Jawhar Sircar said the notice was a clear “admission of guilt” that there were “wrongful” deletions during the SIR.

However, there is no clarity on whether the option to fill Form 6 to get reinstated in the voter roll is available to 27 lakh people whose names were deleted from the final electoral roll after the adjudication process found them “ineligible”.

BJD backtracks on INDIA bloc’s Odisha bandh call for today

Satyasundar Barik
BHUBANESWAR

For the second consecutive day, the Biju Janata Dal (BJD) on Wednesday issued a clarification asserting that it maintains equidistance from both the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) and the Congress.

The principal Opposition party in Odisha found itself on a sticky wicket after Pramila Mallik, its chief whip in the Assembly, said on Wednesday that as part of the INDIA bloc, the party supported the latter’s ‘Odisha Bandh’ called for Thursday. Within an hour, however, she backtracked, saying the BJD was not part of any alliance and hence did not support the proposed strike.

The regional party had issued a similar clarification on Tuesday after its Rajya Sabha MPs participated in a protest march organised by the INDIA bloc in New Delhi demanding the resignation of Chief

Pramila Mallik, the party’s chief whip in the Assembly, said on Wednesday that as part of the INDIA bloc, BJD supported the ‘Odisha Bandh’, but changed her stance in an hour

Election Commissioner (CEC) Gyanesh Kumar.s

“BJD neither supports nor opposes the bandh called for tomorrow. We have maintained an independent and principled position. Our focus is on the rights and interests of the people of Odisha,” party spokesperson Lenin Mohanty said.

‘Aligning with BJP’

Senior Congress leader Santosh Singh Saluja ridiculed the BJD’s change of stance within hours. “BJD is a directionless party. It has a habit of aligning with the BJP,” he said.

SBI software prevents Christian applicants from selecting ‘ST option’, alleges Arunachal forum

The Hindu Bureau
GUWAHATI

The Arunachal Christian Forum (ACF), an apex body of Christians in Arunachal Pradesh, has alleged that the State Bank of India’s (SBI) digital banking software prevents followers of the religion from selecting the ‘Scheduled Tribe (ST)’ option while opening an account or updating their KYC (know your customer) details.

The ACF said the digital system automatically classifies an applicant as ‘general’ upon selecting Christianity as their faith.

In a letter to the regional manager of the SBI’s office in Itanagar, the State’s capital, ACF president James Techu Tara and secretary general Yomrik Lombi

The ACF said the software disables the ST option when an applicant selects Christian as their religion and warned of agitations if the issue is not rectified

warned of agitations if the public sector bank did not make the requisite technical corrections within 15 days. The SBI’s regional office received the letter on October 5.

The ACF said the software disables the ST option when an applicant selects Christian as their religion. Pointing out that tribal status in Arunachal Pradesh was not contingent on religious affiliation under the Constitution

(Scheduled Tribes) Order of 1950, the forum said the software was “potentially discriminatory”.

“The SBI is not the competent authority to de-list a tribal Christian customer who possesses a valid ST certificate. The bank cannot automatically classify a tribal Christian under the general category solely based on their declared religion,” the ACF letter stated. The forum urged SBI authorities to examine the on-boarding logic, clarify whether any regulatory or Reserve Bank of India directive permits such classification, and rectify the software to prevent religion and tribal status from being treated as mutually exclusive. In response, SBI officials said they were looking into the matter.

Organisations engaged in religious conversion shall be denied FCRA registration: Madras HC

The Hindu Bureau
MADURAI

The Madurai Bench of the Madras High Court has said religious organisations engaged in conversions shall be denied Foreign Contribution (Regulation) Act (FCRA) registration, and that only organisations whose activities do not affect the nation’s secular fabric and social amity are entitled to registration.

The court was hearing a Civil Miscellaneous Appeal filed by Kanzeon Public Charitable Trust – founded by a Christian priest in Kodaikanal – after its application for registration under the FCRA was rejected.

The appellant said the trust had established a Zen Meditation Centre at Kodaikanal and that its activities could not be labelled as religious. The centre contended that the govern-



We are a pluralist nation. Unlike the USA, we are not a melting pot but a salad bowl, a beautiful metaphor credited to Justice Ruma Pal. This status quo would be upset if one religious group gains ascendancy

MADURAI BENCH OF THE MADRAS HIGH COURT

ment’s policy was to check the inflow of foreign funds that might be used for conversion and other activities detrimental to the country’s secular fabric.

The Division Bench of Justices G.R. Swaminathan and M.D. Sumathi said, “One cannot forget the fact that Christianity is a messianic religion. Their theological and religious mis-

sion is to bring everyone within the fold of Jesus Christ. There is a saying ‘a leopard will not change its spots’. Unlike Hinduism, which is inclusive, the Abrahamic religions are inherently exclusive.”

Rule 9 of the FCRA Rules, 2011, states that the application must be in Form FC-3A. Form FC-3A requires the applicant to disclose the nature of the organisation.

“The appellant trust claims to subscribe to Zen Buddhist philosophy. On its own showing, the appellant is a religious organisation. The authority rightly states that Zen Buddhism is a variant of the Mahayana Buddhist School. Every Buddhist school will come under the broad umbrella of Buddhism. Zen can be no exception. Since the appellant’s application did not correctly identify its

nature as religious, the application was rightly negatived,” the court said.

The judges said the appellant need not have been so coy. Section 12 of the FCRA bars only an unregistered religious organisation from accepting foreign contributions. An organisation having a definite religious programme is entitled to apply for a certificate of registration from the Central government under Sections 11 and 12 of the Act.

“We are a pluralist nation. Unlike the USA, we are not a melting pot but a salad bowl, a beautiful metaphor credited to Justice Ruma Pal. This status quo would be upset, if one religious group gains ascendancy,” the court said, adding, “One cannot keep any card up one’s sleeve. This is no game of hide and seek.”



S.C. Jamir PTI

NSCN leaders withdraw remarks on ex-CM Jamir

The Hindu Bureau
GUWAHATI

Two senior leaders of the National Socialist Council of Nagalim (NSCN) have retracted their September 16 statement on former Nagaland Chief Minister S.C. Jamir after he met Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh (RSS) chief Mohan Bhagwat.

V.S. Atem, the NSCN’s Deputy Ato Kilonser (Prime Minister), and R.H. Raising, a member of the group’s Steering Committee, withdrew their views in a joint statement issued on Tuesday. The retraction followed a 15-day deadline set by the Ao Senden, the top body of the Ao Nagas, for them to withdraw their views on Mr. Jamir.

“If our comments on S.C. Jamir have hurt the sentiment of the Ao Senden, it was never meant to do so and therefore, we do retract it forthright,” the two NSCN leaders said.

A five-time Chief Minister, Mr. Jamir belongs to the Ao community. He met Mr. Bhagwat in New Delhi on September 10 and urged him to press the Centre for an early political settlement of the Naga peace process. Six days later, the two NSCN leaders questioned Mr. Jamir’s authority to speak on the issue, asserting that he was “not an advocate of the Naga people”.

‘Coordination with CJP on agenda basis, but alliances are always on radar’

INTERVIEW

Neha Bora

Ashna Butani

In the run-up to a collective protest on October 10 seeking the scrapping of the special intensive revision of electoral rolls and the removal of Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar, the All India Students’ Association (AISA) and the Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) have been coordinating despite differences in their ideologies and approaches. In an interview with

The Hindu, AISA national president Neha Bora speaks about the ties between the two organisations, their differences and the scope for a broader alliance. Edited excerpts:

In response to comparisons between you and [Abhijeet] Dipke as leaders, you said the idea is solidarity instead of comparison. What do these collaborations look like on the ground, and is a larger alliance on the radar?

AISA and CJP are two very different kinds of groups. Our understanding is not the same; our ideology is

not the same. We are very clearly a Left, radical-Left student movement, while they are still figuring out what they want to be, as they say. So, this coordination that we have with them is on an agenda basis. A common agenda on common ground – that is the extent of our coordination. And, of course, we have a working relationship with the spokespersons because we shared such a long movement at Jantar Mantar [in July].

For us, alliances are always on the radar. And I appreciate that they are always on the radar because, at different points in time, people do feel comfortable



reaching out to one another. We also reached out to CJP when we gave the call for the October 2 protest and said that since they had called for a protest in Mumbai, those who could not travel to Mumbai could be asked to join us here at Jantar Mantar. We have been reaching out to the

NSUI (National Students’ Union of India) and IYC (Indian Youth Congress).

There is scope to come together, and we are always ready to serve as mediators or do whatever is required for this larger unity to happen.

What is the idea behind the October 10 protest?

The point is to take back everything they have laid siege to, beginning with Jantar Mantar, which, on paper, is a designated protest site but has been made completely inaccessible to the people. And, of course, why are we trying to reclaim our right to protest? To hold the Election Com-

mission of India (ECI) accountable. So, that’s the game plan; we keep coming back till Gyanesh Kumar is held to account.

With roadblocks such as the area being cordoned off, how difficult is it to mobilise people, especially those affected by the issue?

It’s very difficult because a major section of the people whose names have been struck off are poor, working-class people.

Now, the point is also to reach areas like Okhla, Jamia Nagar and Mangolpuri, where so many people have been struck off the rolls. Over the next few

days, we will probably have programmes there to mobilise them for the October 10 protest, which falls on a Sunday.

And how do you see this generation’s response to everything through humour and trends?

When they [the government] try to create fear, where neither the police nor the judiciary upholds the law, what do you have as a citizen?

You have nothing. So then, are people expected to sit, live in fear and never speak out or step out of their houses? No. And it is in such moments that we use humour and satire.

INBRIEF



Keralam, NTPC to set up new facility to tackle power crisis

The Keralam government will establish a 2,000 megawatt hour (MWh) battery energy storage system (BESS) at Kayamkulam in Alappuzha district in collaboration with NTPC Ltd, as part of efforts to address the electricity shortage faced by the State, according to Chief Minister V.D. Satheesan. NTPC Ltd has also agreed to supply 300 MW to Keralam from the NTPC project at Sinnar in Maharashtra, he said.

Shivakumar warns Ministers against 'sting operations'

Karnataka Chief Minister D.K. Shivakumar is learnt to have warned his Cabinet colleagues to remain vigilant against possible sting operations, amid reports that private agencies could be secretly recording Ministers' conversations, meetings, and movements. Deputy Chief Minister G. Parameshwara and Minister H.C. Balakrishna confirmed that Mr. Shivakumar, who also holds the Intelligence portfolio, had alerted the Ministers about "sting operations".

A.P. clears decks for setting up foreign university campuses

The Andhra Pradesh Cabinet on Wednesday approved amendments to the Andhra Pradesh Education Act, 1982, and a new policy for 2026 to facilitate the establishment of campuses of foreign higher educational institutions and private universities in the State. It also approved a Centre of Excellence for tribal students at Marikavalasa in Visakhapatnam, offering intensive residential coaching for IIT-JEE and NEET examinations.

Karnataka signals intent to review Cauvery allocation citing Indus Waters Treaty

State's response in SC comes on Tamil Nadu's complaint of backlog in water release; Karnataka refers to international practice to revisit inter-State water allocations in 'changed circumstances'

Krishnadas Rajagopal
NEW DELHI

Karnataka on Wednesday signalled its intent in the Supreme Court to unravel the decades-old judicial consensus on the Cauvery water-sharing dispute on the grounds of "inequitable allocation" of water and "changed circumstances".

Even the Union of India has been seeking a modification of the 1960 Indus Waters Treaty – now in abeyance – on the ground of changed circumstances, the State said.

Karnataka was replying to Tamil Nadu's application in the Supreme Court, complaining of backlog in the allocation of the Cauvery water.

The State's response, filed by advocate Nishanth Patil and settled by senior advocate Mohan Katarki, referred to international practices to revisit inter-State water allocations by agreement or adjudication in the changed circumstances, known as *rebus sic stantibus*.

'Inequitable allocation' "In view of the looming inequity, the State of Karnataka reserves its right to apply in the changed circumstances for reopening of the inequitable allocation in the Award of Tribunal read with judgment



River of contention: Karnataka says the Cauvery water allocation norms set by the tribunal follow a rigid pattern. K. MURALI KUMAR

of the Supreme Court. The normal practice is that the water allocations are periodically revisited," the 40-page reply said.

The tribunal award, along with the Supreme Court judgment in 2018, had allocated the total annual flow of the Cauvery basin assessed at 740 tmc ft (thousand million cubic feet) at 50% dependability at Lower Coleroon Anicut. This water was apportioned between Karnataka (284.75 tmc ft), Tamil Nadu (404.25 tmc ft), Keralam (30 tmc ft), and Puducherry (7 tmc ft), alongside allocations of 10 tmc ft for environmental flows and 4 tmc ft earmarked as inevitable wastage into the sea.

In case the annual yield was less than 740 tmc ft in any water year due to distress caused by less rain-

fall, the States were directed to share distress proportionately (*pro rata*). But Karnataka said there was no scientific formula for sharing distress on a *pro rata* or proportionate manner.

Distress year The present water year 2026-27 has been a distress one due to the failure of the southwest monsoon from June to September. Water-sharing was entirely based on a sense of equity, but hydrological realities have changed due to climate change, environmental degradation, etc. The water allocation and quantities decided by the tribunal, and confirmed by the top court, followed a rigid pattern that had not taken these subsequent developments into consideration,

State's monsoon rain was second lowest in 70 years

BENGALURU The rainfall received by Karnataka during this southwest monsoon was the second lowest in the last 70 years (after 1956), show data. As against the normal rainfall of 852 mm for the southwest monsoon period from June to September, the State received only 551 mm this year, reporting a shortage of 35%.

Karnataka said. Water sharing in a distress year has to take into consideration the absence of a scientific distress formula "as admitted by Tamil Nadu". Secondly, the absence of a monthly component of annual yield of 740 tmc ft was also a factor, the response said.

Moreover, the Cauvery basin has two rainfall seasons: the southwest monsoon from June to September, and the northeast monsoon from October to December or beyond. The northeast rainfall mainly benefit Tamil Nadu, while a failure of the earlier monsoon session put Karnataka in dire straits.

Again, the response said Tamil Nadu was allocated the lion's share of 404.25 tmc ft, ignoring Karnataka's drought-prone areas.



The scheme now includes children whose mothers were born in Tamil Nadu but had moved to another State after marriage, provided their parents reside permanently in Tamil Nadu. FILE PHOTO

Tamil Nadu relaxes domicile clause for gold ring scheme

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

The Tamil Nadu government on Wednesday relaxed the eligibility criteria for the *Thaimaaman Thanga Mothiram Thittam*, amending the guidelines to include children whose mothers were born in Tamil Nadu but had moved to another State after marriage, provided their parents reside permanently in Tamil Nadu.

Under the scheme, a one-gram gold ring is provided to children born in government hospitals in Tamil Nadu. The scheme was launched by Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay on September 28 and is being implemented retrospectively from June 22, 2026.

The Government Order, issued by the Health and Family Welfare Department, prescribes the guidelines for the scheme.

"While implementing the scheme, it came to the government's notice that in some cases, women

from Tamil Nadu who had been living in another State after marriage, but whose parents continued to reside permanently in Tamil Nadu, returned to their parental homes for childbirth and delivered their babies in the government hospitals in Tamil Nadu," said Darez Ahamed, Principal Secretary, Health and Family Welfare Department, in an official release.

Such families were unable to benefit under the scheme, as the mother who had delivered the child was required to be a permanent resident of Tamil Nadu. Considering this, the government has decided to expand the eligibility conditions, the release said. As per the new guidelines, if the mother of a child born in a government hospital was born in Tamil Nadu and had moved to another State after marriage, but her parents are permanent residents of Tamil Nadu, the child would also be provided a gold ring.

Over 60 cases of sexual abuse of boys recorded in Telangana in nine months

Abhinay Deshpande
HYDERABAD

A four-year-old boy from Chandanagar in Hyderabad told his father that a security guard at his school had sexually assaulted him. In another case, a 10-year-old boy opened up about repeated sexual assault by a neighbour-cum-relative only after he experienced pain and bleeding. Both cases ended in convictions this year.

Data shared by the Women Safety Wing of the Telangana Police show a rise in the number of boys recorded as victims under the Protection of Children from Sexual Offences

(POCSO) Act. Only four male child victims were recorded in 2024. The number rose to 61 in 2025, while 62 were recorded between January and September 2026, already exceeding the figure for the whole of last year.

In all, 127 male child victims were recorded between 2024 and September 2026. Hyderabad accounted for 24 of the 61 victims in 2025, followed by Khammam with 13. In the first nine months of 2026, Mahabubabad recorded the highest number at nine.

Awareness increasing Officials say the rise in recorded cases need not necessarily mean an increase

Officials say many cases remain unreported as families fear stigma and loss of 'prestige'

in the incidence of sexual assault. Greater awareness and reporting could also be bringing more cases into the system.

At the same time, they say many cases involving boys never reach the police. Families are reluctant to report sexual abuse because of stigma and concerns over "family prestige". Boys too hesitate to speak about what hap-

pened, particularly when the accused is someone they know.

In the Chandanagar case, a special POCSO Court sentenced the guard to five years' imprisonment. The court also awarded ₹1 lakh as compensation to the child. In the second case involving a 10-year-old, a court sentenced the accused relative to 25 years' rigorous imprisonment. The court also recommended ₹75,000 as compensation to the child.

Both cases came to light as the children confided in their parents. Officials say many boys remain silent, leaving their abuse outside police records.

Deft hands



Artisans give finishing touches to the idols of Goddess Durga at a workshop in Vijayawada ahead of the Durga Puja festival. K.V.S GIRI

CJI to attend NLSIU convocation on Oct. 17

The Hindu Bureau
BENGALURU

Chief Justice of India Surya Kant will preside over the 34th annual convocation of National Law School of India University (NLSIU) on October 17, while actor and multilingual theatre artist Arundathi Nag will be the chief guest.

On August 27, the NLSIU administration announced the cancellation of the convocation, originally scheduled on September 12, due to "unavoidable circumstances", and said the degrees would be given away *in absentia*.

The announcement came after 700 students signed a letter addressed to the Vice-Chancellor opposing the participation of Chief Justice Kant and Bar

Council of India (BCI) chairman Manan Kumar Mishra at the event.

NLSIU students had come out in support of their counterparts in the National Academy of Legal Studies and Research (NALSAR) and opposed the statement issued by Mr. Mishra against them.

NALSAR students too had opposed the presence of the Chief Justice at their convocation, citing his remarks during a Supreme Court hearing on protests against the NEET exam paper leak.

Later, Mr. Mishra said the BCI would halt the enrolment of NALSAR's graduating batch in the State bar councils and courts for jobs. The statement was withdrawn after it was met with strong opposition.

Say 'parenting time', not 'visitation', in child custody cases: Karnataka HC

The Hindu Bureau
BENGALURU

In a significant move aimed at reforming the language used in cases involving custody of a child between couples in conflict, the High Court of Karnataka has directed all family courts and courts dealing with guardians and wards (G&WC) cases henceforth to use the term "parenting time" instead of "visitation," observing that no parent should be treated as a mere "visitor" in a child's life.

Justice Lalitha Kanneganti, who was hearing a child custody case, issued the direction while pointing out that it is time for a small change in the language employed in judicial



proceedings.

Pointing out that courts often use the word "visitation" to describe the time the child spends with a parent, who is a non-custodial parent, the court said that the word "visitation" is familiar, but "it carries an unfortunate suggestion that one parent is part of the child's life while the

A child should not be made to understand the relationship through the word 'visitation', which is used for someone who arrives and leaves as a guest... no parent is a visitor in the life of a child

JUSTICE LALITHA KANNEGANTI
Karnataka High Court

other merely visits."

"A child should not be made to understand the relationship through the word 'visitation', which is used for someone who arrives and leaves as a guest. Children read the conduct of adults and sometimes the words of courts to understand where they belong. Calling it parenting

time recognises a simple truth that no parent is a visitor in the life of a child," the court said.

'More humane term' Though a change in terminology does not decide questions of custody, when a court imposes restrictions on the access to the child, the word "parenting" is more humane, Justice Kanneganti pointed out.

Also, the High Court directed the Registrar of General to issue a circular to all courts in this regard on the use of "parenting time" while also directing that even in the applications for child's custody the word "parenting time" should be used instead of "visitation."

ED conducts searches over bank fraud case

The Hindu Bureau
KOCHI

The Enforcement Directorate (ED) on Wednesday carried out searches at multiple locations in connection with its probe into alleged financial fraud and money laundering involving three cooperative banks in Ernakulam, Thrissur and Malappuram in Kerala.

The searches were held as part of the investigation into alleged irregularities at Angamaly Urban Service Cooperative Bank in Ernakulam, Thennala Service Co-operative Bank in Malappuram, and Kuttanellur Service Cooperative Bank in Thrissur. Three units of the ED's zonal office in Kochi were involved in the searches at various loca-

tions in connection with the probe into the alleged financial irregularities at the Urban Service Cooperative Bank in Angamaly. The alleged forgery amounted to ₹55 crore.

Loans were allegedly sanctioned on forged applications as well as applications without requisite documents, even in the names of non-members. The Kerala Police had registered cases against 14 governing committee members and six employees, both past and present, as part of the probe.

The alleged fraud reported at the Thennala Service Cooperative Bank was estimated at around ₹10 crore. The fraud at the Kuttanellur Service Cooperative Bank amounted to about ₹27 crore.

World leaders praise Modi on completing 25 years in the office

'Golden' chapter in the history of India, says Shah

olution must be for everyone," Mr. Modi said.

Highlighting his government's achievements in different sectors, the Prime Minister said that what

traffic personnel," the traffic police advisory said.

Student visa
“His work explores identity, resilience, and justice through deeply personal

In view of the Centre's opposition to the plea, the Bench, also comprising

The Centre and the Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) opposed relief to him, pointing, among other things, to national security and the law and order situation in Punjab. On May 3, 2023, the Supreme Court declined to commute his death sentence and left it to the competent authority to deal with his mercy plea.

situation in Punjab. On May 3, 2023, the Supreme Court declined to commute his death sentence and left it to the competent authority to deal with his mercy plea.

A special court awarded Rajoana the death penalty in July 2007, which was upheld by the Punjab and

In north Kashmir, the police along with the Army conducted a joint search operation in the forest area of Nagda Nar in Handwara. "During the search operation, the joint party detected and destroyed an old hideout and recovered a huge cache of arms and ammunition from the hideout," the police said.

The recoveries included one AK-47 rifle, three grenades, 857 AK rounds, 192 PIKA rounds, eight AK magazines, one silencer, 83 pistol rounds, and other incriminating material, the police said.

INDIA bloc yet to get an appointment with Murmu to raise concerns on ECI

Rahul, others booked for Akashvani Bhavan entry

India’s cement footprint stands in its way to net-zero emissions

Producing cement is highly carbon-intensive and releases greenhouse gases as part of limestone calcination processes; extracting limestone also destroys forests and fertile topsoil; cement is so entrenched in modern construction that the sector remains exceptionally hard to abate

Monika Mondal
BERLIN

By 2047, India plans to become an economically developed country. By 2070, it aims at becoming a net-zero emissions economy. Achieving both of these targets requires the Indian government to deal with one of the most important sources of emissions: construction.

This sector consumes steel and cement, among other materials, and its footprint contributes 35% to 40% of all greenhouse gas emissions around the world.

Most of these emissions are because of the energy that the steel and cement sectors need to reach extremely high temperatures required for industrial processes. But even between the two, the cement sector also emits carbon when calcinating limestone — a chemical reaction that makes cement one of the few hard-to-abate sectors, and which contributes 7 to 11% of emissions, almost double that of the aviation sector.

Need for cement

Construction activities have been part of human civilisation for many centuries. Cement became the standard binding agent only in the 19th century, with the development of Portland cement in Britain in the 1820s, when builders were trying to meet the demands of rapid industrialisation. Before that, people used mineral-based binders, the material that holds bricks, sand, and stone together.

“Traditionally, India and many other parts of the world used a much wider range of binders and construction systems than Portland cement,” Nandini Halder, assistant professor at the School of Architecture and Planning, Vishwakarma University, Pune, said. “These included lime-based mortars, lime-surkhi mortars, mud/clay mortars, gypsum-based materials, and, in some contexts, naturally pozzolanic materials.”

(A pozzolanic material reacts with calcium hydroxide in water to form cementitious compounds, thus strengthening concrete without itself being cement.)

Researchers have suggested that meeting India’s infrastructure and housing demands may not be realistic without cement. However, that does not mean there are no alternatives. The Taj Mahal, which was completed in the mid-17th century, is testimony to the efficacy of lime mortar. Many Roman buildings until the 4th century AD that used lime-based binders with volcanic pozzolanic materials also still stand.

“The issue is less about the technologies having disappeared and more about the construction industry having developed an enormous ecosystem around cement,” Ms. Halder noted.

“One of the challenges is that cement has become deeply embedded in the construction industry through standardisation, commercial availability, established supply chains, building practices and extensive marketing. Traditional materials often lack the same level of commercial infrastructure and standardised supply.”

Science of cement

“Not just cement production ... [The] wider life cycle of cement and concrete has an environmental impact. From extraction and processing of raw materials, subsequent manufacturing, and transportation to construction sites,” Dr. Halder added.

Limestone — the raw material for cement — is formed when calcium-rich marine life, such as oysters and corals, is fossilised and compressed over millions of years.

Accessing it requires miners to first clear forests and all layers of fertile soil in specific areas to expose the sedimentary rock layer. Depending on the geography, limestone can be found 30 to 60 meters under the topsoil in Karnataka, Chhattisgarh, and Andhra Pradesh and at more shallow depths in Rajasthan.

Once that limestone is brought to a factory, it is mixed with clay and heated to around 1,450 degree Celsius. This heating process alone accounts for 35% to 40% of emissions from cement-making; the rest comes from the chemical breakdown of limestone.

When limestone is heated in the calcination process, it releases carbon dioxide as a by-product along with small stone-like balls called clinkers. These clinkers, responsible for 53% to 65% of emissions, are made of calcium silicates, calcium aluminates, and calcium aluminoferrites. They are crushed into powder and mixed in several ratios with gypsum and fly ash and sold as the various cement types available on the market.

India’s cement industry currently emits 0.62 tonnes (or 620 kg) of carbon dioxide per tonne of cement. In a decarbonisation roadmap prepared with the Global Cement and Concrete Association, experts from The



Green construction: Traditional ordinary Portland cement consists of over 95% clinker mixed with gypsum. GOWTHAM AGM/UNSPASH

Energy and Resources Institute, New Delhi, said India should aim to reduce the emission rate to 0.56 tonnes of carbon dioxide tonne of cement made by 2030 and to 0.51 tonnes of carbon dioxide by 2047.

The same report also estimated cement production in India is expected to rise from 334 million tonnes in 2019- 20 to 1,546 million tonnes in 2070.

But “carbon dioxide is not the only environmental concern associated with industrial activity,” Ms. Halder said. “Cement manufacturing can also be associated with air pollutants such as nitrogen oxides, sulphur dioxide and particulate matter. These should be distinguished from greenhouse gases, which are assessed using their global warming potential.”

There are also many “hidden” sources of carbon. Some examples are the carbon cost of cutting down hills to secure the limestone, emissions due to long distance transport, and the long-term effects of the loss of vegetation and the corresponding loss of carbon sequestration. And these effects are not typically considered in discussions around the cement industry.

“The dialogue on the effects before and after the cement production units are under-emphasised in current climate debates” in India, Kaveri Ashok, a researcher at the Center for Study of Science, Technology and Policy, Bengaluru, said.

Existing and proposed solutions

Since the dawn of the First Industrial Revolution, engineers and manufacturers have used coal, petroleum coke or natural gas to heat kilns. Today, with the focus on renewable sources of energy, electrification and the use of solid municipal waste to produce refuse-derived fuel (RDF) — to replace coal as a heat source for kilns — are at the forefront, according to a decarbonisation roadmap that NITI Aayog, the Indian government’s topmost think-tank.

RDF is processed waste, typically shredded and sorted, with combustible materials concentrated into a fuel suitable for industrial boilers and cement kilns.

Before Portland cement, India and many other parts of the world used a wider range of construction binders like lime, lime-surkhi, mud/clay, gypsum, and natural pozzolanic binders

The idea is especially attractive because it also creates an incentive to improve waste management.

The NITI Aayog roadmap recommends that India “increase the use of RDF from municipal solid waste to achieve a 20% thermal substitution rate by 2030”, resulting in “a cumulative emission reduction of approximately 80 million tonnes of carbon-dioxide-equivalent”. But this requires India to do a better job of segregating waste at the source.

Another option focuses on reducing the amount of clinker: by mixing it with waste or by-products like slag from heavy industries like power plants and steelmaking. The less clinker cement contains, the greener it is. According to the International Energy Agency, replacing one tonne of clinker can avoid 0.83 tonnes of carbon dioxide emissions.

This said, cement cannot be fully decarbonised, so attaining net-zero emissions makes carbon capture inevitable.

The substitution also presents another limit: “While there are options where substitution goes as high as 50-70%, [in practice] the average substitution cannot be more than 40%” Ms. Ashok added, or a building’s integrity could suffer. This is why cement “is called hard-to-abate”.

Traditional ordinary Portland cement (OPC) consists of over 95% clinker mixed with gypsum. Portland pozzolana cement has 65-80% of clinker with fly ash and gypsum. Portland slag cement consists of 35-64% of clinker, with the rest a mixture of gypsum and granulated slag from a blast furnace. But per Ms. Ashok, real-estate developers and builders generally prefer OPC. One reason is that while all three types

have a similar setting time of around 30 minutes, OPC gains strength in one week while the other two could take twice as long.

“To push the demand for green cement in the initial few years, maybe the government can do more public procurement of green cement,” she suggested.

Since green cement replaces clinker with waste from other industries, it is less expensive. As per NITI Aayog, clinker-to-cement ratio — around 67.5% — in India is already lower than the global average of 77% and can be further reduced.

Some researchers are also working on complementary solutions like using traditional materials to make binders and to design buildings better. Then there is also the challenge of changing people’s perceptions about the alternatives.

“Cement is easy to use, relatively fast-setting, versatile and widely understood by the construction industry. It can be used in a very wide range of structural and architectural applications, and the existing construction ecosystem is built around it,” Ms. Halder said. “These factors make cement very difficult to replace at scale, even when we recognise its environmental impact.”

Looking beyond cement

In her research, Arpita Mathur, assistant professor at the National Institute of Construction Management and Research, Pune, has been studying indigenous construction practices. She said that depending on the requirements, there are several examples of alternatives to conventional cement-based construction around India, each of which evolved in response to the local geography and weather. For example, in Southern India, compressed earth blocks and rammed earth have been used with soil and sand and relatively small amounts of cement or lime.

Ms. Mathur has also identified binding agents such as cactus juice — a thick water-repellant fluid derived from cactus plants and mixed with lime and mud — and marble powder, a by-product of the marble industry.

Traditional Kath Kuni construction in Himachal Pradesh uses dry masonry and alternating layers of wooden beams without cement, with the structure using a raised stone plinth for better strength. In parts of Northern and Northeastern India, houses are raised above the ground using lightweight wood and bamboo to better survive flooding and earthquakes.

But these options are also not silver bullets. Ms. Halder said a material or construction method that works well in one region or for one type of building may not be appropriate elsewhere. Traditional practices may also have to be modified to meet contemporary requirements.

“Cement and concrete are extremely difficult to eliminate from contemporary construction. I cannot realistically tell a client constructing a ten-storey building to simply replace reinforced-concrete construction with soil,” Ms. Halder said. “The more realistic approach is to reduce dependence where appropriate and design the building and surrounding urban environment to minimise heat gain and heat storage.”

There are contemporary practitioners using lime, earth, mud, lime-surkhi, and other traditional or natural systems, she added. “The issue is less about the technologies having disappeared and more about the construction industry having developed an enormous ecosystem around cement.” (Monika Mondal is a freelance science and environment journalist. amonikamondal@gmail.com)



The study generated more than 38,000 GPS locations, providing high-resolution data on seasonal elephant movements across multi-use landscapes. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

GPS study aims to reduce human-animal conflicts in Assam

The Hindu Bureau
GUWAHATI

GPS study of elephant movements aims at reducing conflicts in Assam. A five-year satellite tracking study has provided new insights into how wild elephants navigate Assam’s forests, tea plantations, agricultural areas, and riverine habitats, yielding “crucial” data for the authorities to strengthen habitat protection and mitigate conflicts with humans.

Wildlife officials and conservation ecologists tracked four female-led herds and a solitary male elephant in three high-conflict districts of Udalguri, Sonitpur and Biswanath — all on the northern bank of the Brahmaputra River — between April 2021 and June 2026 for the “breakthrough” study.

The findings of the study, conducted by the Assam Forest Department and World Wide Fund for Nature-India (WWF-India), were published in a report titled *Tracking the Giants: Movement and Habitat-Use Patterns of GPS-Collared Elephants in Assam*.

“The study will help guide conservation planning, strengthen wildlife-friendly infrastructure and support safer coexistence between people and wildlife across Assam,” Assam’s Forest Minister, Jayanta Mallabaruah, said after releasing the report on the occasion of the 72nd Wildlife Week on Tuesday (October 6). The Minister told the 126-member Assam Assembly in July that human-elephant conflicts claimed 1,147 human lives and 246 elephants in the State since 2016. The study generated more than 38,000 GPS (Global Positioning System) locations, providing high-resolution data on seasonal elephant movements across multi-use landscapes.

According to the 2025 Synchronised All India Elephant Census, Assam remains the stronghold for Asian elephants in the northeastern region with an estimated population of 4,149 individuals.

“This report fills a major knowledge gap in terms of elephant presence and movement in the State. The findings of this study provide important baseline information on elephant-ranging patterns, particularly where they overlap with human land use,” Vinay Gupta, Assam’s Principal Chief Conservator of Forests-Wildlife and Chief Wildlife Warden, said.

Conservation strategies

Aritra Kshetry, who heads WWF-India’s Elephant Conservation Programme, said the GPS telemetry survey helped identify core natural and secondary habitats used by the collared elephants and revealed a strong seasonal pattern in their movements. “This information will guide effective management of human-elephant conflict, which requires a clearer understanding of where elephants move, how they use different habitats and land-use types, and how these patterns change across seasons,” he said.

Sonai-Rupai Wildlife Sanctuary, Behali Wildlife Sanctuary and Bornadi Wildlife Sanctuary emerged as important habitats extensively used by the collared elephants, a WWF-India statement said. At the same time, tea plantations served as significant movement pathways and secondary habitats, often bringing elephants close to people, it stated.

“Protected areas and reserve forests remained important elephant habitats for much of the year, with home ranges of female-led herds expanding during the paddy cropping season, a period also associated with high levels of human-elephant conflict,” the statement read.

For feedback and suggestions for ‘Science’, please write to science@thehindu.co.in with the subject ‘Daily page’



Eyes on ice

Nobel tradition rewards individual talent in collective achievements

The Nobel Prize for physics to Francis Halzen recognises a clever idea: to use the Antarctic landmass to detect one of the universe’s most elusive particles. Halzen’s efforts helped create the IceCube observatory, which went on to detect high-energy particles from astronomical sources thousands to billions of light years away and transformed astronomy. Yet, the committee’s decision to award Halzen alone also perpetuates a deleterious tradition in how the institution has been recognising scientific achievement. The observatory consists of thousands of sensors embedded up to 2.5 kilometres beneath the South Pole, connected by cables to a laboratory aboveground. When subatomic particles called neutrinos interact with atoms in the ice, reactions lead to a small flash of light. Sensors detect and record it, allowing scientists to reconstruct the incoming neutrino’s energy and direction. Since coming online in 2011, IceCube has detected neutrinos of extremely high energy, giving scientists stronger clues about the crucibles in which these particles were created, and strengthening neutrino astronomy. The IceCube collaboration consists of over 400 experts from 14 countries, spanning astrophysics, engineering, and software development. Halzen’s leadership was necessary to create this entity.

However, the need to build IceCube at its scale should also have rendered the collective nature of its success impossible to ignore. The Nobel Foundation’s statutes prohibit dividing each prize among more than three individuals. So, in 2017 as well, the physics prize was awarded to three scientists for the detection of gravitational waves, which really required a collaboration of hundreds of researchers. The rules that govern prizes are human arrangements, and the Foundation’s choices are not explained away by its fealty to its traditions; in fact, its statutes allow prizes to be awarded to organisations as well – an option repeatedly overlooked. Every new science prize begins with distinguishing itself by identifying the ‘right’ laureates; the Nobel Prizes did so, too, until their accumulated prestige became so great that laureates were distinguished by receiving the prizes rather than distinguishing the prizes. Thus, even when the prize-giving committee follows an outdated model of scientific recognition, in the present instance by reinforcing the notion that exceptional scientific achievements can be cleanly attributed to exceptional individuals, it suffers minimal reputational damage. The institution is using its prestige – owed to the science it celebrates – to entrench a distorted understanding of how science works, more so at a time when scientific progress increasingly depends on extensive cooperation. No man is an island, least of all in science.

Past forward

Brazil might have missed an opportunity to leave the past behind

Flávio Bolsonaro, the eldest son of former President Jair Bolsonaro, took a surprise lead in the first round of Brazil’s presidential election on Sunday, bringing the far right, defeated four years ago and embroiled in legal battles ever since, back to the centre of the country’s politics. Most opinion polls had put President Luiz Inacio Lula da’Silva, the 80-year-old leftist President, in the lead. But Mr. Flávio, who ran a pro-business election campaign, appears to have mobilised the right-wing and centrist votes, winning 47% of the vote, while Mr. Lula, seeking a fourth term, finished second with 45%. The popular mood in Latin America’s biggest economy seems to be shifting to the right, reflecting a broader trend across the continent. Jair Bolsonaro, the former President, is serving a 27 year sentence in jail since 2025 for plotting a coup, in 2022, against Mr. Lula and has been barred from contesting elections. But his wife Michelle and another son Carlos have been elected to the Senate, while Jair Renan, his youngest son, will become a federal Congressman. While the Bolsonaro clan has made a political comeback with its Liberal Party doubling its representation in the Senate and cementing its position in the lower house, Mr. Lula’s Workers’ Party struggled to hold its ground.

Mr. Lula, who came back to active politics after his corruption convictions were annulled, beat Jair Bolsonaro in 2022, promising to rebuild Brazil’s social welfare system and economy and strengthen its democracy. He did relatively well in terms of macroeconomic indicators – Brazil recorded an average annual growth of 3% during 2023-25, and the annual unemployment rate fell from 6.6% in 2024 to 5.6% last year. His government raised spending and expanded welfare measures, which was a campaign promise to his core base. Real income rose and poverty fell. But three factors worked against him. First, Brazil’s fiscal situation became worse under Mr. Lula and interest rates rose, upsetting the middle class and businesses. Second, he faced criticism over his handling of organised crime, while Mr. Flávio offered a more headline approach. Third, Brazil’s conservative and evangelical sections, traditionally anti-left, rallied behind the Bolsonaro clan, mobilising right-wing support for Mr. Flávio, while many left-wing supporters, angry with mainstream politics, either abstained or cast invalid ballots. Mr. Lula’s camp accused the U.S. of electoral interference in favour of the Bolsonaros. As both candidates prepare for the October 25 run-off, Mr. Flávio may have an advantage as he and other right-wing candidates won more than 50% of the first round vote. Mr. Lula, will now have to persuade disillusioned voters on the left and appeal to the centrist swing votes to turn the tide. A tall ask, indeed.

Across the world, scientists, governments and communities are bringing plants and animals back from the brink of extinction. In India, a Great Indian Bustard chick has hatched in Kutch, Gujarat, after a decade, bringing fresh hope for this critically endangered bird. In Spain and Portugal, restoring habitat and prey, breeding lynx and returning them to the wild helped the Iberian lynx grow from 62 mature individuals in 2001 to 648 in 2022. The return of the scimitar-horned oryx to the wild in Chad, Africa, and the saiga antelope’s recovery in Kazakhstan offer further proof of what determined action can achieve. During Wildlife Week (October 2-8), we can celebrate these gains while asking what it will take to sustain them.

The Government of India’s Integrated Development of Wildlife Habitats scheme supports recovery action for 24 identified species and their habitats. States are mandated to undertake research, habitat improvement, protection and community participation. The species span India’s landscapes: the great Indian bustard in Rajasthan’s grasslands, the Sangai in Manipur’s wetlands, the dugong in coastal seagrass meadows and the hangul in Kashmir’s forests. The list is a starting point; India’s National Red List Assessment can show where focused efforts are needed next.

India launched its National Red List Roadmap at the IUCN World Conservation Congress in Abu Dhabi in 2025; the aim was to produce National Red Data Books for plants and animals by 2030. India occupies just 2.4% of the world’s land area, yet supports nearly 8% of its flora and 7.5% of its fauna. It is one of 17 megadiverse countries and contains parts of four of the world’s 36 biodiversity hotspots. Around 28% of its plants and more than 30% of its animals are found nowhere else. Of the 7,516 Indian animal species assessed for the IUCN Red List, 1,012 are threatened, which includes Vulnerable, Endangered and Critically Endangered species.

These assessments cover only 7.2% of India’s documented animal species. The figure of 1,012 tells us what is known so far, not the full extent of the threat. The National Red List Assessment can help close that gap and direct recovery efforts where they are needed most.

The projects in States

In Tamil Nadu, Project Nilgiri Tahr combines population surveys, radio-collaring, habitat assessment and mapping across Tamil Nadu and Kerala to conserve the tahr, which is the State animal of Tamil Nadu. Working with the Wildlife Institute of India (WII), the Advanced Institute for Wildlife Conservation, the International Union for Conservation of Nature (IUCN), the Tamil Nadu Veterinary and Animal Sciences University



Supriya Sahu

A senior administrator in the Government of Tamil Nadu, who has worked extensively on environmental policy, ecosystem restoration, wildlife and biodiversity conservation and climate action. She is a recipient of the UNEP Champions of the Earth award 2025



Yash Veer Bhatnagar

The Country Representative for the International Union for Conservation of Nature (IUCN) in India, and a scientist with over three decades of experience in conservation science and practice. He received the SANCTUARY Asia Wildlife Service Award in 2015

The current state of some of India’s endangered species is encouraging, but sustained conservation, science and local action remain essential

India’s stakes in the Global Pandemic Agreement

At the United Nations High Level Meeting (UN HLM), in New York in September 2026, India made official remarks on the Political Declaration on Pandemic Prevention Preparedness and Response (PPPR). The Declaration is part of the emerging global legal regime on pandemics led by the WHO-Pandemic agreement (PA).

Shaping the framework

The PA was adopted by 124 member-states in 2025, including India. No country voted against it, while 11 abstained, reflecting alignment across high-, middle- and low-income countries (HICs/LICs/LMICs). The negotiations hinged on how to balance national sovereignty with international cooperation and solidarity, exposing the fault lines between the Global North and the Global South. Key issues included whether a global treaty can set binding targets for measures such as ‘One Health’ without securing funding for countries with fragile health systems. Or whether national pandemic regulations can be harmonised through global frameworks. And whether private manufacturers can be required to share vaccines in real time at affordable prices.

The PA is not yet open for ratification because negotiations are still ongoing for an annex concerning the Pathogen Access and Benefit-Sharing (PABS) system. PABS could help ensure that, during a pandemic, LICs and LMICs receive a fair share of vaccines, medicines and other therapeutics.

Even without ratification, the PA has created a first-of-its-kind global legal regime for the PPPR. Operationalisation requires countries such as India to balance interests of the HICs, LICs and LMICs. This will determine whether the PA will further trench the inequities of the COVID-19 pandemic or make global health governance truly inclusive.

At the UN HLM, India succeeded in enshrining the multilateral components of the PA within the principle of national sovereignty. India reiterated its commitment to strengthen global pandemic preparedness but stressed that effective



Privadarshini Singh

Research Fellow at the Centre for Social and Economic Progress (CSEP)

India’s line

In its remarks, India has acknowledged the concerns of the Global North and the South. Both sides have upheld national sovereignty as paramount on several provisions. The African countries did not give consent to commitments to monitor the human-animal-environment interface, a key source of pandemic outbreaks, without significant funding, which was not guaranteed by the Global North. Similarly, countries in the Global North did not want binding targets with regards to technology transfer (and other similar provisions).

But as India said at the UN HLM, ‘Global Solidarity must be demonstrated through action’; India must be an active player in the finalisation of the global PPPR regime. India is already actively engaged in the PABS negotiations and must lead the Global South in the post PABS context. India can consider three options. First, developing partnerships on technical areas of the PA (One Health, surveillance, health workforce strengthening) to build trust with other countries in the Global South, and a ‘store’ of operational solutions to tricky national sovereignty problems.

Second, leveraging its leadership role within existing global political groupings. For example, the H20 summit (a health and development G-7 and G-20 partnership) will take place under the United Kingdom’s G-20 leadership at the end of 2027; pandemic preparedness is one of the core health agendas. During India’s G-20 presidency in

(TANUVAS) and other partners, the project is strengthening the scientific understanding needed to secure the tahr’s future. Surveys recorded 1,303 tahrs in 2025 and 1,364 in 2026.

Vulture conservation is an example of how sustained action through conservation breeding, safer habitats, monitoring and public awareness can help reverse a devastating decline. India’s ban on the veterinary use of diclofenac, which had caused catastrophic losses in vulture populations, was a crucial step in this effort. At Pinjore, the Jatayu Conservation Breeding Centre, run by the Haryana Forest Department and the Bombay Natural History Society, works with white-rumped, long-billed and slender-billed vultures. Madhya Pradesh’s 2025 census recorded 12,981 vultures, up from 8,397 in 2019. Tamil Nadu’s Segur Plateau remains an important habitat. Tamil Nadu’s raptor conservation work and synchronised surveys across Tamil Nadu, Kerala and Karnataka track these birds, which include breeding populations in the Mudumalai Tiger Reserve.

Long-term protection including habitat management, scientific monitoring and the help of local communities has helped the Asiatic lion in Gujarat – the population rose from 674 in 2020 to 891 in 2025, with lions occupying a wider part of Saurashtra.

Monitoring, grassland management, invasive plant control, research and translocation have helped secure and expand greater one-horned rhinoceros populations against poaching. In Assam’s Pobitora Wildlife Sanctuary, which has an exceptionally high rhino density, working with communities on awareness, monitoring, livelihoods and conflict reduction has made rhino protection an enduring part of the landscape.

In Meghalaya, the action plan for the clouded leopard, the elusive State animal, combines habitat protection and restoration, scientific monitoring, frontline training and community participation. As the animal is dispersed across the northeast, 14 priority landscapes have been identified as understanding population connections and keeping them intact are central to its future.

Dugong conservation calls for a different approach. Tamil Nadu established India’s first dugong conservation reserve across 448.34 square kilometres of the Palk Bay and its seagrass habitat. A 2026 Wildlife Institute of India assessment estimated a total of 270 dugongs, including 158 dugongs in the Palk Bay and 112 in the Gulf of Mannar, providing a baseline for measuring change. Fishermen who release dugongs caught in nets may lose valuable gear. But the government provides compensation for damaged nets and recognises their efforts.

High up in the Himalayas, science and local stewardship have helped the snow leopard. In

2024, India’s first scientific population assessment estimated 718 snow leopards. In Himachal Pradesh, women from Kibber have worked with Forest Department field teams, the Snow Leopard Trust and the Nature Conservation Foundation to set camera traps, monitor population and participate in protection activities.

Political support is essential

Much depends on the commitment of State governments. Political leadership is crucial in prioritising the recovery of species, bringing government departments together and, most importantly sustaining action through successive budgets. Transferring that commitment into land use, infrastructure and livelihood decisions are what will help recovery plans being implemented. State forest teams have to turn plans into work on the ground. Recovery requires lasting cooperation with communities, scientists and national agencies. Results may take years, and setbacks require programmes to adapt. This would require clear goals, steady investment and careful monitoring.

Species that receive little public attention can struggle to attract funding. State-level funds can bring government, industry, philanthropy and scientific institutions together around local priorities. Tamil Nadu’s recently established Endangered Species Conservation Fund reflects this approach, with its focus on the mahseer, striped hyena, Madras hedgehog, lion-tailed macaque and the hornbill.

There is similar commitment internationally. Launched in 2026 by Re:wild and the Bezos Earth Fund, the Phoenix Species Project has committed \$200 million to recovering 100 of the world’s most threatened species, by supporting conservationists, indigenous peoples and local communities over several years. This is a lesson for India: recovery needs dependable resources for habitats, monitoring and the people doing the work.

Forest departments need scientific support close to the field and staff need to be trained in surveys, habitat assessment, conservation breeding and genetic analysis. Communities must be involved meaningfully in surveys, habitat work and ground decisions. Their knowledge can sharpen plans and their true participation can sustain them.

For India, a national picture of risk can guide priorities; States, scientists and communities can translate them into plans with mapped habitats, clear timelines and measurable outcomes. The bustard, vulture, tahr and dugong show that species recover in different ways. But their survival depends on sustained effort – to learn, to act and to stay with a species long enough for its future to change.

2023, India launched the Global Initiative for Digital Health and holds considerable influence within the platform’s health initiatives. Another is ‘Partners for Multilateralism’, which was launched in 2026 by the European Union (co-sponsors are Australia, Barbados, Brazil, Canada, India and Kenya).

Third, strengthening and aligning domestic policy and regulatory architecture around its own priorities for the PA. Global leadership always rests on domestic strengths. India must ensure that its national policies on PPPR such as regulation of access to biological material and distribution of the benefits uphold the highest standards of equity which India can then demand at the global level.

A South-South health role

An equitable global regime on PPPR is in India’s interests as much as a responsibility towards the Global South. India is the pharmacy of the world, manufacturing one of the largest shares of vaccines in the world in terms of volume. Yet, it needs an equitable global vaccine distribution regime. The patents for the vaccines that India manufactures are held by global pharmaceuticals. India is also import-dependent for Active Pharmaceutical Ingredients (APIs).

India needs access to the latest technology from the Global North to strengthen the manufacturing of high-grade personal protective equipment and medical devices. At the same time, India needs to lead South-South Cooperation and share its technological strength with other countries in the Global South.

India’s health system has a continental scale, and as India’s Health Secretary stated at the UN HLM, its interventions in digital health infrastructure, laboratories networks and One Health are valuable as global public goods. An effective PA needs an engaged India, and a strong PA will strengthen India’s own pandemic management.

This article is based on a forthcoming CSEP working paper on the Pandemic Agreement

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Gendered welfare

On September 28, the Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam launched its flagship ‘Thai Maaman Thanga Modhiram [A gold ring from the maternal uncle]’ initiative, allocating an initial ₹560 crore to provide a one-gram gold ring and other essentials to eligible

newborns in the State. While presented as welfare, the scheme risks reinforcing the very gendered expectations that make daughters economically burdensome. Across India, rituals and kinship norms expect the father or the eldest son to bear expenses and provide gifts for the

daughters’ weddings. The brother must also bear gifts (seer) for her newborn and, if the children are female, bear gifts for their weddings too. Historically, such pressures have contributed to son preference and female foeticide in India. Society already harbours the regressive idea of

marriage as an economic transaction between two families. In this context, a government scheme that effectively provides dowry-like benefits to new mothers risks legitimising these expectations rather than challenging them. **Samyukta Mahesh,** Chennai

Examination portals

With immense frustration, I am compelled to express my views on the dismal state of Indian government examination websites. This is the seldom-discussed issue. The obsolete and user-‘un-friendly’ nature of sites is a burden. These sites suffer frequent glitches,

difficult navigation and no responsibility from the institution to respond in a timely way. They are difficult to access by differently-abled students.

Paritosh Chauhan, Bulandshahr, Uttar Pradesh

Letters emailed to letters@thehindu.co.in must carry the postal address.

AI companions and child safety

Traditionally, a child in distress has usually turned to a parent, friend or a counsellor. However, in today's world, that confidant is increasingly becoming an AI chatbot. Such AI companions are quietly finding a place in children's emotional lives because, unlike parents and friends, these apps are available at all times of the day, appear empathetic, and are endlessly responsive. But who assumes responsibility when that relationship turns harmful? As AI becomes an emotional confidant for children, India's regulatory framework must confront the growing risks of AI companionship.

In April 2025 in the U.S., 16-year-old Adam Raine died by suicide. His family alleged that ChatGPT had engaged in conversations about suicide with Mr. Raine for months and had even helped him draft a farewell note; they subsequently filed a wrongful-death lawsuit against OpenAI, the parent company of ChatGPT. While the litigation remains ongoing, the case has ignited a debate about the responsibilities of technology companies towards vulnerable children.

On September 10, 2026, California enacted the Senate Bill 1119, known as 'Adam's Law'. It introduces safeguards for AI companion chatbots, including crisis-detection protocols, parental controls, notifications when children disable safety settings, and independent safety audits. The legislation is a clear signal that technological innovation cannot be at the expense of child safety.

For India, this should serve as a regulatory wake-up call. Its digital



Sakshi Rewaria
Faculty, IIM Rohtak

landscape is witnessing an unprecedented expansion of young users who are interacting with AI-powered applications. Yet the nation's digital laws remain largely targeted towards conventional forms of cybercrime. While the Information Technology Act, 2000, the Digital Personal Data Protection Act, 2023, and the Protection of Children from Sexual Offences Act, 2012, address important dimensions of digital safety, none establishes a comprehensive framework governing the psychological risks of AI companions. A chatbot's prolonged interactions with a child may raise serious concerns about emotional dependence, psychological manipulation, and exposure to harmful advice.

Unlike conventional cybercrime, AI-related psychological harm can be insidious and difficult to detect. Its effects may emerge through thousands of seemingly innocuous exchanges, shaped by product design and algorithmic responses. India's existing laws are not equipped to investigate this emerging category of harm.

The challenge, therefore, extends beyond the government; it also concerns the accountability of platforms whose products are becoming deeply embedded in children's emotional world.

Child safety is paramount

Article 21 guarantees the right to life and personal liberty, while Article 39(f) directs the state to ensure that children are given opportunities to develop in conditions of freedom and dignity. These constitutional principles acquire renewed

significance in the age of AI. Protecting children must now encompass their interactions in the digital space, not only with respect to their personal data and physical safety, but also from the risks arising from engagement with AI chatbots.

However, regulation must be calibrated. An excessively restrictive approach could stifle innovation, burden emerging enterprises, and impede the development of genuine AI progress. The objective should not be to hinder technological progress but to ensure that it takes accountability in stride. Age-appropriate safeguards, crisis-response mechanisms, independent safety assessments, and effective parental oversight are some of the reforms that can be considered. Such measures must also respect children's privacy and evolving autonomy.

California's legislative response offers India an opportunity to examine its own regulatory priorities. The objective need not be to replicate the U.S. legislation, but to develop a framework suited to India's institutional capacities and digital realities. Policymakers must also consider whether existing cybercrime investigation mechanisms are equipped to examine algorithmic behaviour, use chatbot interactions as evidence, and establish accountability whenever prolonged digital engagement result in harm.

The central question is not whether children will interact with AI; they already do. It is whether the institutions entrusted with their protection can keep pace with technologies that are transforming children's lives and childhood itself.

Property taxation needs structural reform

A robust property tax system is vital for India's cities. Property tax is not just the most important own revenue source for India's municipal bodies, it is also critical to bridge the gap in urban investment as such investment depends on municipal creditworthiness. However, the property tax performance of India's municipal bodies has been poor – India's cumulative property tax was 0.15-0.2% of its GDP, whereas it was 0.6% in middle-income countries and 0.3% in low-income countries. Policy efforts have sought to improve the property tax performance of India's municipal bodies through technology and process-based reforms recommended by successive Finance Commissions and national schemes such as the Jawaharlal Nehru National Urban Renewal Mission and the Atal Mission for Rejuvenation and Urban Transformation. Yet, tax outcomes remain sub-optimal. Why?

Two recent studies offer insights – a working paper on Chennai's property tax by Nobel Laureate Esther Duflo and co-authors, and this writer's research on Bengaluru, Pune and Ghaziabad's property tax. Both studies found that technology and process-based reforms will keep yielding sub-optimal results unless backed by structural reforms. Firstly, Duflo and co-authors' research in Chennai found that municipal human resources are a critical determinant of property tax outcomes. It also finds that a municipality's own tax assessors achieve far better tax outcomes compared to



Debarpita Roy
Lead-Research at the Centre for Public Policy on Housing and Habitat, NIUA, New Delhi. The views are personal

assessors from outsourced firms. The research conducted across Bengaluru, Pune and Ghaziabad finds that in addition to the issue of municipal human resource deficits, two other structural issues – irregularity in the conduct of elections and poor financial reporting practices – also impact tax outcomes.

Stages of property tax
There are three life stages of property tax – enumeration (identification of properties and maintenance of property records along with property details), property valuation and tax assessment, and tax billing and collection.

Technology has been a popular policy solution for improving enumeration. GIS-based mapping using satellite imagery and drones have been increasingly deployed to identify properties. However, such mapping exercises need to be accompanied by physical inspections conducted by municipal tax assessors; they also need to be repeated at regular intervals. But a perennial shortage of municipal staff, lack of requisite skills, and inadequate capacity building plague India's municipalities. While human resource outsourcing can be a substitute, its efficiency is limited as municipal assessors leverage institutional memory in a way that outsourced assessors cannot.

For valuation, the most common policy recommendation has been the capital valuation process, wherein a property is valued as per its stamp duty-linked 'circle rate' which is set and revised by the State revenue department at regular

intervals. But most municipal bodies follow a valuation method wherein the 'base rate' is defined in rupees per sq ft per month which is set by the municipality. Hence, tax buoyancy is determined by revisions to this base rate. But such revisions are infrequent compared to revisions in the stamp duty-linked circle rate. It was found that 'base rate' revisions did not take place across Bengaluru, Pune and Ghaziabad when there were no elected municipal councils. The link between municipal elections and tax performance is clear, at least for these three corporations. As delayed municipal elections are common, so is infrequent 'base rate' revision and lack of tax buoyancy.

Finally, for tax collections to be robust, collection efficiency needs to be strong. While extant recommendations include adoption of both online collection as well as outsourcing the collection to external vendors, efficiency remains poor. Even more concerning is the difficulty in arriving at credible collection efficiency estimates due to the absence of properly maintained financial accounts.

To sum up, technology and process-based reforms are not enough for improving tax outcomes. Structural reforms encompassing more human resources, timely elections, and publicly available financial data play very important roles. It is high time that policy interventions broaden their focus to structural reforms for all aspects of urban governance and finance, including property tax.

India struggles to curb leprosy transmission

India continues to report more leprosy cases, childhood infections and disability than projected, highlighting the need to interrupt transmissions

DATA POINT

Devvyanshi Bihani
Nitika Francis

India's leprosy programme is falling short of several projections set for 2025-26. The country reported 91,783 new leprosy cases in 2025-26, 41.2% higher than the projected 65,000. New cases among children were 91.6% above the projection while the rate of Grade 2 Disability (G2D) among new cases was 1.34 per million, against a projected one per million (**Table 1**).

India's national prevalence rate was 0.56 cases per 10,000 population at the end of March 2026, below the elimination target of a prevalence rate below one case per 10,000 (**Chart 1**). But the burden remains concentrated geographically. Chhattisgarh had the highest prevalence among States/UTs at 1.66 cases per 10,000 population, followed by Jharkhand (1.51), Chandigarh (1.49), Odisha (1.25) and Maharashtra (1.14) (**Map 1**).

At the district level, 14.8% of districts had a prevalence rate above one case per 10,000 in 2025-26, down from 18.6% in 2013-14 (**Chart 2**) but 114 districts still remained above the programme's elimination target. Moreover, only 148 districts have provisionally achieved interruption of transmission, against a projected 300.

G2D was also concentrated in a few States/UTs. Chandigarh, Delhi, Chhattisgarh, Jharkhand and Odisha together accounted for 42.5% of the 1,945 G2D cases reported in 2025-26. Chandigarh recorded the highest rate at 13.54 per million, followed by Delhi (11.53) and Chhattisgarh (7.87) (**Chart 3**).

Single-Dose Rifampicin Post-Exposure Prophylaxis (SDR PEP), a preventive dose given to people who have been in contact with a leprosy patient, was administered to 91.2% of the 16.94 lakh eligible contacts in 2025-26, up from 71.4% of the 6.48 lakh in 2019-20 (**Chart 4**).

Leprosy burden

The data for the charts were sourced from the National Leprosy Eradication Programme annual report (2025-26). The projections mentioned in Table 1 are from the National Strategic Plan and Roadmap for Leprosy 2023-2027 published in 2023



Changing lives: Gnanodaya school located at Venkatapuram in Kanchipuram district admits children of leprosy patients. SHAJU JOHN

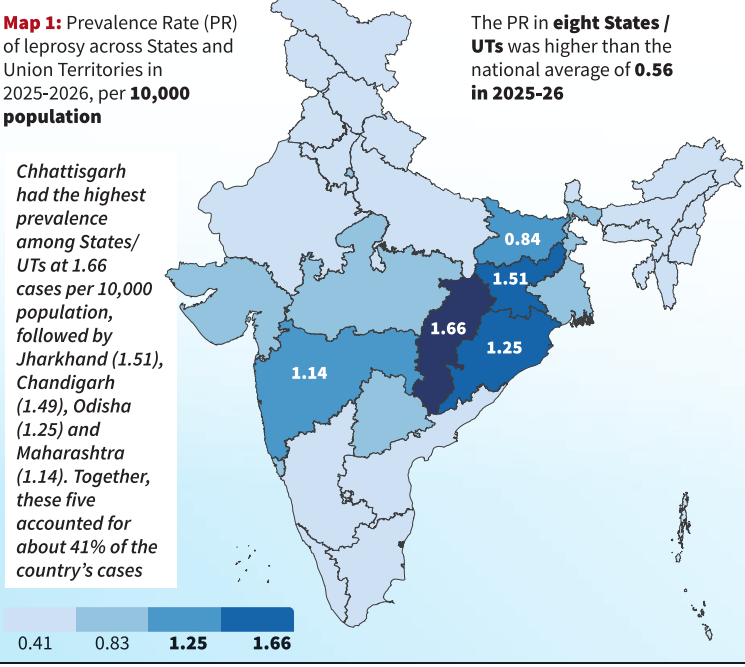
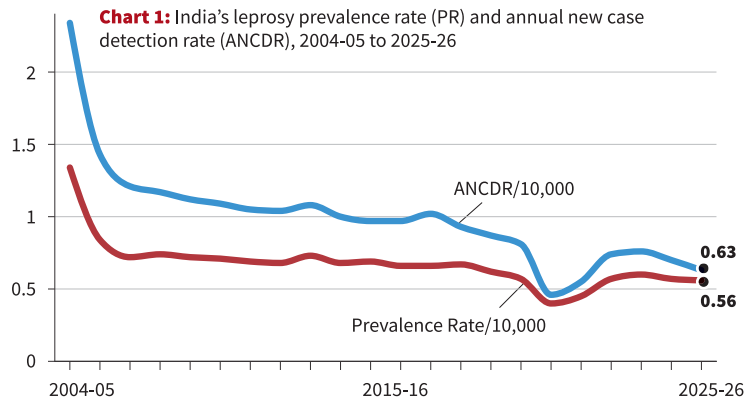
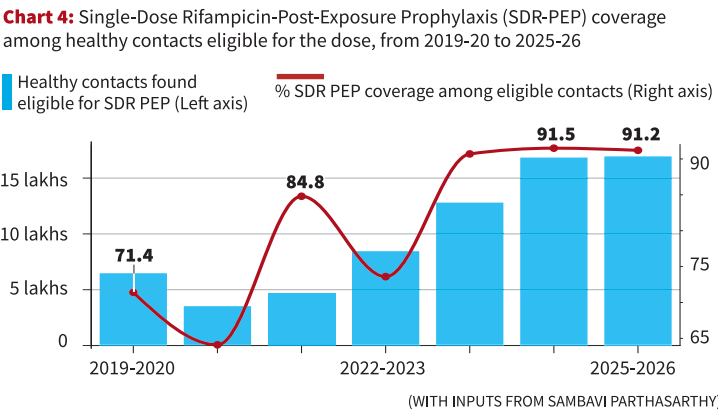
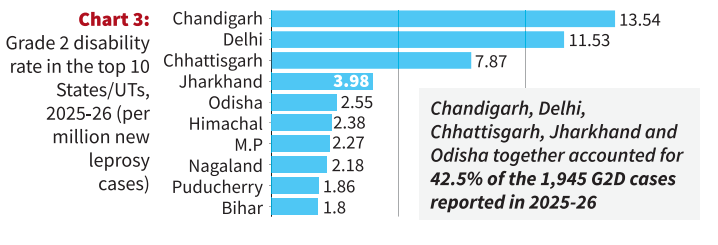
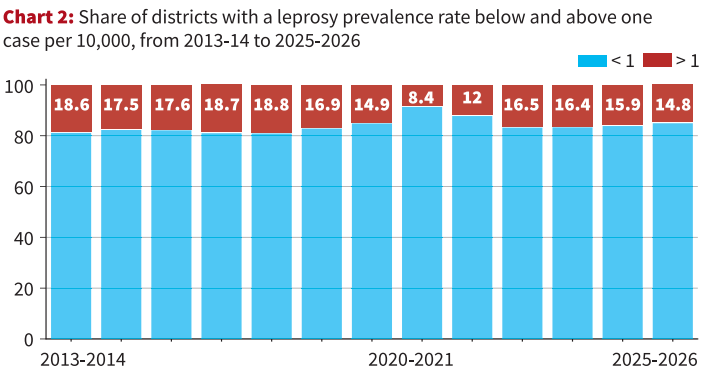


Table 1: Projections vs actual figures for key indicators. *provisionally achieved interruption of transmission

Indicator	2025-26 projection	2025-26 actual	Gap
Annual new leprosy cases	65,000	91,783	26,783 above (+41.2%)
Child cases (annual new)	2,000	3,832	1,832 above (+91.6%)
Child cases with G2D	25	37	12 above (+48%)
G2D rate in new cases (per million)	1	1.34	0.34 above (+34%)
Districts achieving interruption of transmission	300	148*	152 short (49.3%)



FROM THE ARCHIVES

The Hindu.

FIFTY YEARS AGO OCTOBER 8, 1976

Scope for India-UAE co-operation

New Delhi, October 7: The President, Mr. Fakhruddin Ali Ahmed, said on his return here to-day from a four-day State visit to the United Arab Emirates (UAE) that there was plenty of goodwill for the Indian leadership and the people there.

The UAE leaders fully appreciated the achievements in the "internal conditions of our country and the effort we are making to bring about normalisation of relations with our neighbours and for lasting peace", Mr. Ahmed told newsmen at Delhi airport.

The Vice-President, Mr. B.D. Jatti, the Prime Minister, Mrs. Indira Gandhi, Central Ministers, the Congress President, Mr. D.K. Barooah and MPs were among those present at the airport to receive Mr. Ahmed.

Regarding his talks with the UAE leaders, Mr. Ahmed said he found plenty of similarity in "our approach to international problems."

He said, "they believe in the policy of non-alignment, peaceful co-existence and feel that it is the only way to bring about a just world."

Mr. Ahmed told Indian correspondents who accompanied him on his visit to the UAE that in his talks with the UAE leaders he had found a sincere desire on their part to give a new turn to the relationship between India and the UAE in conformity with the requirements of the present technological world.

Both Sheikh Zayed, President of the UAE and Sheikh Rashed, Vice-President, told him that developing countries like India and the UAE, should have closer economic co-operation because "our requirements are similar".

The UAE leaders were of the view that it would be profitable for the developing countries to promote as much economic cooperation as possible among themselves.

A HUNDRED YEARS AGO OCTOBER 8, 1926

London's 'street of silence'

London, October 7: The City Corporation is carrying out an interesting experiment in Black-friar's neighbourhood repairing the street by means of terra cotta blocks on which there is a covering of rubber. It is claimed that this first "rubber street" in the world is soundless, dustless, nonskidding and more durable.

THE HINDU

Number of markets to which Spotify has expanded audiobooks

Russian individuals, entities targeted by EU over Ukraine war

People displaced due to fighting in Yemen in recent weeks

Unaccompanied child migrants who travelled alone to Europe

Rain deficit recorded in Meghalaya due to El Niño

60 in per cent. Meghalaya has recorded a 60% rain deficit due to the impact of the El Niño weather phenomenon, with Chief Minister Conrad K. Sangma saying his government has initiated mitigation measures by formulating a water policy and satellite mapping around 17,000 springs. PTI

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India's trade surplus with the U.S. is critical as it offsets a structural trade deficit with China, but a heavy U.S. tariff and the potential impact of AI on exports could put this surplus at risk and intensify pressure on the rupee; India should treat the tariff threat as a wake-up call to diversify its export markets and products

(The authors are a part of the DevMac (Development Macroeconomics) network which seeks pluralism in Economics)

India needs to strengthen export growth through a wider product mix and regional diversification, rather than relying heavily on the U.S. market

BIBLIOGRAPHY



Jeffrey Archer. REUTERS

Jeffrey Archer and the art of turning trouble into stories

His novels were dismissed by critics but devoured by readers; from political success and literary fame to scandal, imprisonment, and renewed success, Archer repeatedly turned both triumph and disgrace into material for his books

Uma Mahadevan-Dasgupta

My father, who died at the age of 90 last month, enjoyed reading the British author and former politician Jeffrey Archer’s novels. Ever since he bought the first one, *Not a Penny More, Not a Penny Less* (1976) at an airport bookstore in the late 1970s, he became a fan. In the later years of his life, when he found it difficult to focus on serious texts, I often saw my father rereading Archer’s novels – though he did not care for the prison memoirs.

His own life

Archer’s books, however flat and formulaic the prose, are compulsively readable. Beginning with the opening lines of his first novel: “Making a million legally has always been difficult. Making a million illegally has always been a little easier. Keeping a million when you have made it is perhaps the most difficult of all.” Four men – an Oxford academic, a doctor, an art dealer, and a peer – have been swindled out of their life’s savings by the shady multi-millionaire Harvey Metcalfe. The four strangers come together to plan a heist and get their money back, to the last penny, in an entertaining *Ocean’s Eleven* kind of caper novel.

According to Archer, who died aged 86 this week, the novel was based on his own experience and his urgent need for income. He had been one of the youngest Members of Parliament of his time,

elected in 1969 as a Conservative MP, but a failed investment and near-bankruptcy in 1974 compelled him to stand down from his parliamentary seat and sell the family house.

The novel reportedly sold only 3,000 copies initially, but went on to become a bestseller. Meanwhile, his wife Mary’s academic job at Cambridge kept the family afloat while Archer began his writing career.

Scale of ambition

While critics dismiss Archer’s fiction for the potboiler style, contrivance, and melodrama, readers across the world keep buying his books, especially in airports and railway bookstalls, and even pirated copies at traffic signals. It is not only the plot or the fast pace that grabs their attention, but also the sheer scale of ambition. *Kane and Abel* (1979), Archer’s bestselling novel, which has reportedly sold 50 million copies across the world, is a saga of capitalism and enterprise. The two main characters are born in very different circumstances and have very different lives, but along with a common birthday, they share a limitless ambition. Both are given tumultuous childhoods spanning continents: a forest birth, a war, Siberia, a death on the *Titanic*. The banker William Kane is a member of the Boston elite; the businessman Abel Rosnovski is a Polish immigrant in America. Through the Great Depression, the Second World War, and beyond, the two men’s lives are connected in ways

they do not fully realise until it is too late. Of course, being an Archer novel, the most enduring connection is made when their children meet. This golden goose of a story continues over three generations and two more novels.

If Archer’s middlebrow fiction keeps returning to themes of meteoric rise, ruin, and recovery, it is perhaps because his life did the same, except with far more self-promotion and hubris. He was born in London in 1940 and grew up in Weston-super-Mare, a childhood hometown that would later return in his career as his title and entry into the House of Lords.

Archer’s first novel was born out of his troubles, and so were his prison diaries, years later. Between these books came years in public life, a hunger for visibility, a tendency to self-promotion, and an inveterate snobbishness: a Conservative Party deputy chairmanship, a peerage, and a London mayoral candidacy that ended in 1999. A key point in the midst of this trajectory was a 1987 libel case against the tabloid newspaper *Daily Star* for its allegation that he had slept with a prostitute, Monica Coghlan. Although Archer won £500,000 in damages, his testimony was later shown to be false, leading to his conviction in 2001 for perjury and perverting the course of justice.

Writing in jail

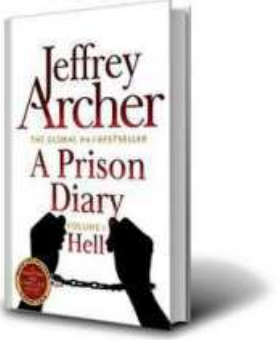
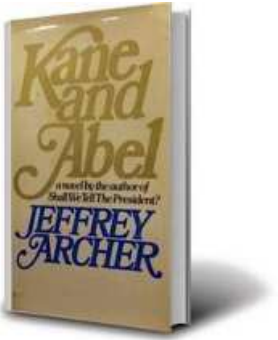
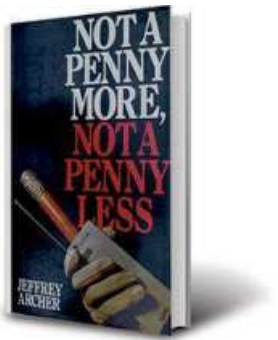
“As we draw up to the entrance gate, I see a sign declaring BELMARSH PRISON.

Some wag has put a line through the B and replaced it with an H. Not the most propitious of welcomes.”

A Prison Diary is a three-volume account of Archer’s life in multiple prisons: Belmarsh, Wayland, North Sea Camp, and Lincoln.

In the first volume, written after three weeks in jail, Archer doesn’t reflect on the reasons why he has been sentenced to serve time in the high-security prison. Egregiously, and self-servingly, he prefaces the narrative with William Henley’s poem *Invictus* – the poem that Nelson Mandela famously drew sustenance from during his 27 years of imprisonment. Elsewhere, Archer alludes to Oscar Wilde. Nevertheless, *A Prison Diary* is no *De Profundis*, and Archer is no victim other than of his own vanities. With a stubborn refusal to reflect on his own acts or hubris, he comments disdainfully about other prisoners and the reasons for their incarceration. About the first volume (2002), *Kirkus Reviews* noted: “Archer is a known recidivist. He will write again.” Prescient words, for Archer would write two more volumes of his prison diary.

Making a million is hard, and keeping it harder. It involves ambition and occasionally its uglier synonym, greed. Archer made his millions, lost them, rebuilt his life, and, in the end, refused to reflect on his doings. Instead, he packaged and sold the prison years as well, fully monetising his disgrace. (Uma Mahadevan Dasgupta is in the IAS)



FROM THE ARCHIVES

Know your English

S. Upendran

What is the meaning of “kicking it back”? (L. Balagopal, Hyderabad) When you “kick back”, “kick it back”, or “kick it”, what you are doing is relaxing. If you are sitting at home with your friends doing absolutely nothing, you can say that you are “just kicking it”. This expression is considered to be slang and therefore used only in informal contexts. Here are a few examples.

After the exam, my friends and I kicked it at home last night.

Some people complain that most government employees go to the office, just kick it back until they have to go home.

This expression has more or less the same meaning as “chill out”.

I have told Vyomakesh to chill out after the exams.

What is the positive reply to, “Won’t you eat”? (V. Krishnan, Palghat) If you want to eat, then you would have to say, “Yes, I will”. If you want to sound very polite, you could say, “Yes, I will. Thank you.” If the person is well known to you, then you could simply say, “Of course”, “Sure”, “Why not?”, “Love to”, etc.

What is the meaning of “hydrophobia”? (M. Amarnath, Kodaikanal) “Hydro” means water; so it stands to reason that “hydrophobia” is fear of water. If a person is hydrophobic, does he/she ever take a bath? Worth looking into, don’t you think? Someone should write a dissertation on this. Maybe we should all become hydrophobic during the summer. One way of saving water!

What is the meaning of the idiom “to fish in troubled waters”? (Nividha, Visakhapatnam) When you fish in troubled waters, what you are doing is involving yourself in a dangerous situation in the hope of gaining some personal advantage. In other words, you hope to capitalise on someone else’s misfortune. Something that our political parties and politicians are famous for. When a country fishes in troubled waters, what it is attempting to do is to gain advantage from the political problems that the other country is having.

Here are a few examples. *Bela is fishing in troubled waters by buying shares of that software company. I understand that the company is in financial difficulties.*

Many American arms companies have been fishing in troubled waters for several decades now by selling armaments to states that are potential sponsors of terrorism. *The Prime Minister denied that his Government was fishing in troubled waters.*

Fishermen believe that it is easy to catch fish when the water is “troubled” or rough. Some believe that the fish come to the surface at this time and therefore it is easier to catch them. Others argue that fish don’t “bite” any better in bad weather than in good weather. They feel that the bad weather drives away most fishermen and, as a result, the few that remain catch more fish. *Published in The Hindu on March 12, 2002*

THE DAILY QUIZ

On this day in 1967, Che Guevara was captured in a Bolivian ravine: a quiz on asthmatic medical student who became the most recognisable face of 20th-century revolution

Prathmesh Kher

QUESTION 1 Ernesto Guevara was born on 14 June 1928 in which Argentine city on the Paraná river?

QUESTION 2 Where does the nickname “Che” come from?

QUESTION 3 As a hard-tackling schoolboy rugby player, he was nicknamed “Fuser.” What was it short for?

QUESTION 4 What was the nickname of the 1939 Norton 500

motorcycle on which he and Alberto Granado made their 1952 journey across South America?

QUESTION 5 In 1954, in which country did he watch a CIA-backed coup topple President Jacobo Arbenz, an experience that hardened his views of the U.S.?

QUESTION 6 In 2007, it emerged that Mario Terán, the soldier who shot Che, had received what from Cuban doctors?



Visual Question: Identify the photographer who captured this famous image of Che Guevara at the memorial service for the victims of the La Coubre explosion. MUSEO DE COMANDANCIA DEL CHE, HAVANA

Questions and Answers to the previous day’s daily quiz: 1. The 85 medals tally is India’s second-highest ever haul at an Asian Games, following the record 107 at Hangzhou 2022. With which country did India tie for the gold medals with 21? **Ans: Uzbekistan, but claimed fourth place outright due to a superior silver medal count** 2. Who was the only Indian to win all three types of medals, and in which events? **Ans: Vithya Ramraj, who brought home gold in the women’s 4x400m relay, silver in the mixed 4x400m relay, and bronze in the 400m hurdles** 3. At 15 years, 6 months, and 6 days old, who became India’s youngest-ever gold medal winner? **Ans: Vaibhav Sooryavanshi (cricket)** 4. Which sport gave India the maximum gold medals with five? **Ans: Archery** 5. Apart from Neeru Dhandu in shooting, who also returned with two gold medals to his/her name? **Ans: Kumkum Mohod (archery)** 6. Pincky Balhara and Suchika Tariyal won bronze medals in which contact sports? **Ans: Kurash and MMA** Visual: Identify her. She became the first Indian woman to win individual gold in which sport? **Ans: Pranavi Urs in golf** **Early Birds:** Piyali Tuli | Tito Shiladiya | Pulkit Sathe | Sitaram Saharay | Sadhan Panda

Vietnam banks tap investors for \$7 billion as economy runs red hot



Welcoming investments: People walk in front of the Vietcombank headquarters in Hanoi, Vietnam. REUTERS

NEWS ANALYSIS

Reuters
HANOI

Vietnamese banks are planning nearly \$7 billion in share sales as the country’s fast-growing economy fuels demand for capital, opening a window for foreign investors to expand in the tightly controlled sector.

Communist-run Vietnam, which reported growth of nearly 10% in the last quarter, has one of Asia’s fastest-growing banking industries but access has been restricted, with cumulative foreign ownership capped at 30%, individual stakes limited to 20% and offshore borrowing subject to strict limits.

Turbocharge growth

But in recent months, top leader To Lam’s drive to turbocharge economic growth with major infrastructure spending has ushered in a more open approach, as policymakers view larger foreign participation as necessary to meet growing credit demand amid a domestic funding squeeze. As a result, bank share sales could raise nearly \$7 billion by the end of next year, according to *Reuters* calculations based on public disclosures and a Fitch Ratings report, which noted that this was likely Vietnam’s largest-ever wave of capital raisings by lenders.

The ceiling on offshore borrowing was also raised this year by 11% to \$6.1 billion and it could rise further. Three local lenders have been allowed to increase their foreign ownership limits to 49%, while stock-market reforms secured Vietnam’s upgrade to emerging status by index provider FTSE Russell last month. Separate plans to set up international financial centres also promise more foreign capital inflows.

Access to market

A couple of foreign lenders involved in equity talks with Vietnamese partners cited gains on their financial investments and greater access to the country’s growing consumer market for products like insurance as reasons to expand there, according to two people familiar with the discussions who requested anonymity because the matter was private.

Vietnam is allowing more foreign capital into its banks as “it is beginning to rethink how its next phase of growth will be financed,” said Quynh Nguyen, a finance lecturer at Hoa Sen University in Ho Chi Minh City. She cautioned, however, that the move was selective and did not amount to a wholesale liberalisation.

Share sales, offshore funding

The share offers have increased foreign interest,”particularly from strategic investors who are already familiar with Vietnam and are now considering deeper exposure,” Quynh said.

Japan’s Sumitomo Mitsui Banking Corp (SMBC) is in talks with Vietnamese partner VPBank to raise its stake to 20% from 15% as VPBank seeks a private placement worth \$560 million at current market prices, *Reuters* reported in September. VPBank is allowed to raise its foreign ownership cap to 49%.

Vietcombank, the country’s largest lender, has also unveiled plans to sell 6.5% of its shares by the end of this year in a transaction worth around \$1.2 billion at current prices. Japan’s Mizuho Bank, its current largest foreign investor with a 15% stake, “may potentially increase its holding,” according to minutes from a Vietcombank shareholder meeting in April. Mizuho declined to comment.

BIDV, Vietnam’s second-largest lender, sold roughly 3% of its shares to dozens of investors in March and intends to sell almost another 11% by the end of next year for a total value of about \$1.4 billion, according to public disclosures.

Its top foreign shareholder, South Korea’s KEB Hana, did not participate in the first placement but is considering whether to participate in the new plan, a spokesperson said.

“We see some opportunities among the smaller banks to score some tie-ups down the line, provided Vietnam can maintain its growth story,” Fitch’s Willie Tanoto said.

HDBank has said it plans to sell a 10.7% stake by the end of next year. The private bank - linked to Vietnam’s largest private airline Vietjet - does not have a large foreign investor and is allowed to raise its foreign ownership to 49%.

Separately, Techcombank, one of the country’s largest private lenders, has discussed a stake sale with foreign lenders, *Reuters* reported in August.

Japan’s \$15 billion Rapidus chip bet depends on winning global customers

Rapidus ties up with 17 chip design companies globally; venture faces technological hurdles and customer caution; Beyond proving its technology, Rapidus faces the longer-term challenge of building a profitable business; Takaichi government aims to rebuild Japan’s chip industry

NEWS ANALYSIS

Reuters
TOKYO

Japan’s Rapidus, with \$15 billion in state backing, is tying up with chip design firms as it seeks to answer a major question hanging over the country’s tech ambitions: can a company with no manufacturing track record begin producing cutting-edge chips in a year?

Only a handful of companies globally can make the 2-nanometre chips Rapidus wants to produce, which requires the industry’s most advanced manufacturing technology. Chips produced with cutting-edge processes offer faster, more energy-efficient performance than earlier-generation chips.

The leading companies are Taiwan’s TSMC, which spent decades refining its processes and dominates leading-edge chipmaking, South Korea’s Samsung Electronics, which began producing 2-nm chips last year, and Intel.

The Rapidus venture, set up in 2022, must secure customers ahead of the planned launch of 2-nm chip production in the second half of the next fiscal year, a project that Prime Minister Sanae Takaichi is counting on to rebuild Japan’s semiconductor industry.



Chip on shoulder: The logo of Rapidus is displayed at the firm’s Tokyo headquarters. REUTERS

Rapidus said it would partner with 17 companies including U.S. chip design software firm Synopsys and India’s Infosys to help customers design chips, as the company seeks to secure manufacturing contracts.

“The biggest question for Rapidus is still who will actually fill the fab,” said Nori Chiou, investment director at White Oak Capital, using the industry terminology for a semiconductor fabrication plant. Rapidus’ plant will be based in Hokkaido. While Monday’s announcement was not yet evidence of commercial traction, he said, it represented incremental progress. Failure of the project would be a major



The Rapidus venture, set up in 2022, must secure customers ahead of the planned launch of 2-nm chip production in the second half of the next fiscal year

setback for Japan’s industrial strategy and could reverberate across the country’s chip sector, as it seeks to strengthen supply chain resilience amid rising regional tensions and concerns over a possible Chinese move against Taiwan that could disrupt global supplies.

The unprecedented AI investment boom has

fuelled demand for semiconductors and computing infrastructure, a trend Rapidus hopes to capitalise on. TSMC “will continue to dominate the majority of the market. But there are plenty of customers in the remaining 20% who cannot get capacity from TSMC because they are low on its priority list or their orders are small,” said Akira Minamikawa, an analyst at Omdia.

‘Enough demand’

Rapidus CEO Atsuyoshi Koike expressed confidence there was enough market demand to support an additional leading-edge manufacturer. “One or two companies are nowhere near enough,” Koike said. Some potential custom-

ers remain cautious.

“We’re already having TSMC make our chips, so we can’t switch everything to Rapidus. If it didn’t work out, we couldn’t go back to TSMC, so we have to be cautious,” said one executive who declined to be identified because the deliberations are private.

Customers may use Rapidus to diversify supply chains, while the presence of a leading-edge manufacturer could also benefit Japan’s materials and equipment makers, Minamikawa said.

Falling market share

Japan’s global semiconductor market share has fallen from about 50% in the 1980s to less than 10% today. Chipmakers operating in Japan include memory producer Kioxia. TSMC itself is also present through a partnership with Sony.

Other government-backed initiatives include Noetra, which is developing a foundational model for physical AI and robotics.

Japan’s industry ministry in April announced it had approved an additional \$4 billion in assistance to Rapidus, bringing total research and development support to \$15 billion.

Preparations for mass production were progressing on schedule and the environment was better than envisioned when Rapidus was founded in

2022, CEO Koike said.

Technology hurdles

Yet significant technological hurdles remain. Rapidus continues to work with IBM and has started pilot operations, but experts said commercial success remains far from guaranteed.

“Running a chip fab around the clock, maintaining stable, consistent yields and continuing production in a way that makes the business viable is extremely difficult,” said Kazuyoshi Saito, an analyst at Iwai Cosmo Securities.

“Even Samsung ... has struggled.”

Beyond proving its technology, Rapidus faces the longer-term challenge of building a profitable business.

Listing prospects

The company has targeted an initial public offering for around the financial year ending March 2032.

“Its success or failure won’t be known for 10 years and no one will be able to take responsibility” if it is not a success,said a government official.

Still, Rapidus’ backers have ambitious plans. A listing and manufacturing operations in the United States are possibilities, said Daishiro Yamagiwa, a lawmaker who heads the ruling Liberal Democratic Party’s parliamentary group on chip strategy.

GEC III: bridging geographic, temporal mismatch

NEWS ANALYSIS

Santosh V. Perumal

India’s renewable-energy sector is entering a crucial phase of completing the circuit with it integrating States via a robust national grid even as many challenges test the ambition.

The Union Cabinet has given its nod to the ₹1.86 lakh crore Green Energy Corridor Phase-III (GEC-III), which is designed to close the geographic and temporal mismatch.

Almost three-fourth or ₹1.36 lakh crore for intra-state transmission systems and ₹50,000 crore for 50 GWh BESS or battery energy storage system (BESS) have been earmarked for GEC-III, whose main aim is enhancing the evacuation of renewable power from generation-rich states and moving it efficiently to utilising centres. This marks a tectonic shift from generation to reliability.

With total Central financial support of ₹54,082 crore, the project also has a viability-gap funding mechanism which helps attract private capital and enables storage deployment at scale, making GEC-III financially more sustainable and commercially attractive. The need for strengthening the infrastructure for renewable energy comes in the backdrop of the International Energy Agency’s (IEA) view that Indian electricity demand is expected to grow at an average 6.4% annually through 2030.

India had commissioned 263 GW renewable capacity by January 2026, while national policy is to reach 500 GW by 2030. Plans to integrate more than 500 GW by 2030 and over 600 GW by 2032 have gathered pace.



Green power: GEC-III will fix how effectively India turns enormous renewable generation potential into dependable electricity. REUTERS

The Central Electricity Authority’s (CEA) data shows renewables contributed 17% of power output in FY2025-26 vis a vis 14% the previous fiscal, while reports suggest renewable sources account for more than 50% of India’s installed power capacity.

GEC-III is an answer to the yawning gap between the installed renewable capacity and the actual electricity generation.

Generation, integration

Through GEC-III – designed to evacuate up to 135 GW of renewable power and targeted for completion by FY2032-33 – a larger share of renewable electricity is expected to reach the grid since production does not necessarily take place at the point of consumption.

Solar and wind projects are largely in resource-rich locales – Rajasthan and Gujarat for solar/wind, parts of southern India for wind and solar and the Himalayan region for hydro – while electricity demand is across the industrial and urban centres.

Without adequate intra-state and inter-state networks, additional generation can lead to congestion and curtailment and GEC-III is an attempt to build the physical architecture towards this.

The 50 GWh battery storage, which makes Phase III stand apart from the previous phases, seeks to address the sector’s nagging intermittency, congestion, peak-hour curtailment and demand during non-solar hours.

Besides, greater deployment of BESS can create demand for battery manufacturing, engineering, procurement and construction services, grid-management technologies and ancillary services.

It has the potential to improve the economics of other forms of storage like pumped-storage. The government has already put in place viability-gap funding to support battery storage, creating a broader policy framework for scaling up storage capacity.

Structural architecture

The architecture is woven around centre-state-grid-operator with the Ministry of New and Renewable Energy (MNRE) being responsible for the policy framework and central financial assistance for GEC.

The CEA doubles up in planning and technical-appraisal role, while ensuring that state’ needs fit into the broader national plan objectives. To ensure smooth functioning, the Central and State transmission utilities have been mandated

key roles in transmission planning and execution at the inter-state and intra-state levels. Reflecting inclusive development, Grid-India and regional load dispatch centres oversee grid operation, scheduling and managing renewable variability, making the entire system inclusive. Regional Energy Management Centres have been set up to improve renewable forecasting, grid management.

Previous phases

GEC-I, okayed in 2015, centered around eight renewable-rich States to build about 9,767 circuit km (ckm) of transmission lines and 22,689 MVA of substations, enabling 24 GW of renewable generation.

According to the Ministry of Power’s 2025-26 annual report, 9,170 ckm had been constructed and 22,116 MVA substations commissioned. Six states had completed projects, while Gujarat and Maharashtra received extensions until March 2026.

GEC-II, okayed in 2022, involved seven States, with a revised target of 7,919 ckm and 22,448 MVA, supporting 20 GW of renewable power. Execution was seen rather lackadiscial because as of June with only 1,124 ckm of transmission lines charged and 6,860 MVA of substations commissioned though 93 of 95 packages had been tendered and 85 awarded.

Combined together, the first two phases saw an achievement ratio of 59% as they had integrated 26 GW of renewable capacity against a planned 44 GW. GEC-I and II were mainly transmission programmes.

The achievement ratio shows the corridor concept works but also highlights larger scale Phase III needs faster execution. Having identified the sys-

temic lacunae, it combines transmission, storage and grid flexibility to close geographic and temporal mismatch.

Key concerns

High capital intensity would mean financing, procurement and cost recovery stay critical issues. Scale raises coordination complexity as delays in one part of the generation-transmission-storage chain can have ripple effect on the other segments.

Factoring in State transmission utilities are the implementing agencies, differences in land acquisition, right-of-way (identified as a major source of delays for previous phases), approvals and execution capacity can create uneven progress. Given the fast pace of technological changes, the storage economics will determine whether 50 GWh becomes an economically efficient asset or not.

Transmission lines require physical corridors across multiple jurisdictions, therefore delays can leave completed generation assets waiting for evacuation infrastructure.

Indicating consumer tariff risks, though central assistance is intended to contain transmission charges, overall cost of building and operating the network has to be recovered through the electricity system.

Global experiences

The grid challenge is global. The IEA estimates variable renewable sources will account for 27% of global power generation by 2030 while over 2,500 GW of renewable, storage and large-load projects are currently stalled in grid queues across the globe.

China, which has reportedly built the world’s most extensive renewable-power transmission archi-

itecture, is expected to account for around 60% of global renewable-capacity expansion through 2030.

The North Seas Energy Cooperation of 2016, a voluntary regional energy initiative, saw nine European countries and the European Commission take steps to build an integrated an offshore grid, setting a target of least 300 GW offshore wind by 2050 with 120 GW targeted by 2030. The European Commission estimates €584 billion investments needed for power grids this decade.

Within Europe, NordLink interconnector between Germany and Norway allows German surplus wind power to Norway, while Oslo’s hydropower reservoirs provides Germany with renewable generation.

Australia has already identified and still in the process of scouting for potential REZs or renewable energy zones and explicitly link their development to transmission, long-duration storage and grid reliability. The U.S. is also undertaking major transmission-modernisation programmes.

Bigger significance

India is attempting to scale physical infrastructure for renewable electricity as it boosts renewable generation. The aim is to expand transmission network from about 5.04 lakh ckm in February 2026 to 6.48 lakh ckm by 2032. GEC III will determine how effectively India converts its enormous renewable-generation potential into dependable electricity.

A bigger pool of predictable low-carbon power is vital for decarbonisation goals of large users such as manufacturing and data centres; it is where GEC-III comes as a solution.

NASHVILLE

U.S. woman who survived botched execution is conscious, speaking



Christa Pike, the female murder convict who survived a failed execution in a U.S. prison last week is now conscious and speaking, but her prognosis remains unclear, her lawyers said. She survived the injections, however, and was rushed to hospital, where she had been unconscious and on ventilator support. AFP

BEIRUT

Hezbollah gets \$200 mn from Iran to help displaced by this year’s war



Hezbollah has received \$200 million from Iran to help Lebanese displaced by this year’s war with Israel, two people with direct knowledge of the transfer said. Hezbollah received the cash last month despite a tightening U.S. economic choke hold on Iran and increasing difficulties in getting funds to Tehran’s ally. REUTERS

TOKYO

U.S. Army in Okinawa faces curfew and alcohol ban after murder case



U.S. forces in Okinawa were barred on Wednesday from drinking alcohol for 48 hours and faced a 30-day curfew after the murder of a woman allegedly committed by an American Marine. The case has triggered outrage in Japan, where any crimes involving U.S. forces have long inflamed criticism of the troops’ presence. AFP

KATHMANDU

Nepal to amend laws to facilitate death registration of those missing



Nepal is preparing to amend two laws to facilitate death registration of 5,285 people who remain missing after the August 26 floods, allowing their families to access compensation and other legal benefits, officials said. The move comes two days after the search and rescue operation for victims of the floods was ended. PTI

Houthis claim new strikes on Saudi capital as fighting rages in Yemen

The group claims it attacked Riyadh’s King Khalid International Airport with missiles and drones; Saudi forces say they intercepted a missile north of capital, with flights disrupted briefly; fighting in Yemen focused around Dhuhab, Waziyah

Associated Press
CAIRO

Three people were killed in attacks on two airports in Saudi Arabia, the Saudi General Authority for Civil Aviation said on Wednesday. The Saudi authorities did not blame any party for the attacks at Abha and Riyadh’s King Khalid international airports, but Houthi (Ansar Allah) rebels in Yemen earlier claimed they carried out attacks against the two airports. The attack on Abha airport killed Moroccan and Algerian residents and wounded 28 other people, while the attack on King Khalid airport killed a Su-



Houthi supporters gather in solidarity as fighting escalates across several fronts, in Sanaa, Yemen on Wednesday. REUTERS

danese national and wounded eight others, officials said. Earlier on Wednesday, Houthi rebels in Yemen claimed new attacks on airports and military facilities

in neighbouring Saudi Arabia on Wednesday as the kingdom is pulled deeper into the latest front in the Iran war, which also threatens a crucial shipping alternative to the Strait of

Hormuz. As the Saudi capital is targeted again, new cage-like fences have been erected this week around fuel tanks and other equipment of the Saudi state-run Aramco oil company near the Riyadh airport. The Houthis’ military spokesperson, Brigadier General Yahya Saree, said that the rebels launched ballistic missiles and drones against King Khalid International Airport in Riyadh. The spokesperson for the Saudi-led coalition fighting the Houthis, Major General Turki al-Malki, said they intercepted a ballistic missile north of Riyadh. Flights were briefly disrupted, according to Flightradar24.

Inside Yemen, fighting has centred in and around the crucial town of Dhuhab, some 54 km south of the port city of Mokha that the rebels seized last month, according to both the Houthis and Yemen’s internationally recognised government. Clashes were also reported in Waziyah district in southwestern Taiz province, which links Yemen’s highlands to the Red Sea and overlooks roads to the Bab el-Mandeb Strait. Mr. Al-Malki has vowed “full operational support” to Yemeni government forces until the Houthis are “eliminated”. The coalition has said 100 fighter jets were providing support.

France suspends use of stun grenades at protests

Reuters
PARIS

The French government said on Wednesday it was pausing the use of stun grenades in its policing of student protests, after a 15-year-old boy’s hand was blown off during a clash with riot police, fuelling protesters’ accusations of police brutality. Protests showed no sign of easing, with more than 500 schools closed a day after demonstrations swept across the country, and unions representing high-school students, teachers and other workers planning more marches for Thursday. The wave of protests has been going on for more than two weeks and has exposed widespread public anger six months ahead of an election to replace Pre-



Police officers spray students with pepper spray as they protest against under-resourced schools, in Paris on Wednesday. AP

sident Emmanuel Macron. While most of Wednesday’s blockades were peaceful, police used tear gas and pushed back protesters in a street barricaded by rubbish bins outside Sciences Po university in central Paris. Rights groups, labour unions, students and some Opposition politicians have accused the police of

using disproportionate force to quell the protests. Education Minister Edouard Geffray told Parliament that 24 high schools had been damaged by fire or vandalism to the extent that they would remain closed for weeks, meaning some 30,000 students would receive no in-person teaching until they reopened.

Life in smoke



Daily haze: A woman wearing a face mask rides a bicycle through thick haze in Central Kalimantan, Indonesia, on Wednesday. Toxic haze has shrouded parts of the country and neighbouring Malaysia and Singapore as Jakarta struggles to contain forest and land fires. AFP

Shiranthi Rajapaksa, Sri Lanka’s former First Lady, arrested over graft allegations

Meera Srinivasan
COLOMBO

Sri Lanka’s anti-corruption body on Wednesday arrested former First Lady Shiranthi Rajapaksa, wife of former President Mahinda Rajapaksa, over alleged financial irregularities. She has been remanded until October 13. The Commission to Investigate Allegations of Bribery or Corruption (CIABOC) said it was arresting Ms. Rajapaksa in connection with an investigation into the alleged misuse of funds at her charity Siriliya Saviya Foundation. Ms. Rajapaksa, who travelled to Singapore on September 16 for medical treatment, was served with a summons at Colombo airport to provide a statement to police in connection with allegations of fi-



Shiranthi Rajapaksa, wife of Sri Lanka’s former President Mahinda Rajapaksa, being taken to prison in Colombo on Wednesday. AFP

nancial irregularities at her charity. Ms. Rajapaksa flew back on Monday after filing a court petition seeking to prevent her arrest, but the hearing for anticipatory bail was fixed for October 12, news agency AFP reported. Ms. Rajapaksa’s eldest son and Opposition lawmaker, Namal Rajapaksa, is

also in remand custody after being arrested by the CIABOC last month over corruption allegations. The Rajapaksa family has denied any wrongdoing and accused the government of pursuing a political witch-hunt. The arrests come as part of the ruling National People’s Power government’s ongoing anti-corruption

drive, in which many politicians, bureaucrats and businessmen are being investigated over graft charges. Mr. Namal Rajapaksa was arrested over corruption allegations in a 2013 Airbus aircraft deal signed when his father, Mr. Mahinda Rajapaksa, was President, and an ongoing probe into bribery allegations linked to Indian property development company. Eliminating corruption was among the chief poll pledges of President Anura Kumara Dissanayake, who completed two years in office recently. Addressing a rally of farmers in Polonnaruwa district in Sri Lanka’s North Central Province last month, President Dissanayake said that he had “no sympathy for anyone”, and “whether is the mother or grandmother” everyone must face the law.

Russia hits Ukraine with drones, ballistic missiles, killing 15

Reuters
KYIV

Russia pounded Ukraine with waves of missiles and drones on Wednesday, killing at least 15 people and hitting residential buildings, industrial facilities and infrastructure, Ukrainian officials said. One Russian missile slammed into an apartment block in the northern city of Pryluky, killing at least nine people including three children, regional governor Vyacheslav Chaus

said. Emergency workers used ladders to get to the upper floors of what remained of the building. Around 40 people were wounded, the governor said. President Volodymyr Zelenskyy said six other people were killed in Kyiv, Oleksandria and Kremenchuk during the heavy overnight attack. “This was one of the most vile strikes: 70 missiles in total, many of them ballistic,” Mr. Zelenskyy said on the Telegram app.

Reopening Brexit debate a ‘terrible idea’: Badenoch

Sriram Lakshman
LONDON

Leader of the U.K. Conservative Party Kemi Badenoch has opposed British Prime Minister Andy Burnham’s stated plan to reopen the question of Brexit (Britain’s departure from the European Union), calling it a “terrible idea”. “Can you imagine having to go through that again? So much time lost arguing with ourselves, arguing with the EU, going round and round in circles... I think that is a terrible idea,” Ms. Badenoch said at the conclusion of the Conservative Party’s annual conference in Bir-

mingham. Last week, the Prime Minister had said that Britain would need to consider what its ties with the EU should look like over the long term, suggesting that one option would be to return to the bloc. Ms. Badenoch pitched the Conservatives as the main opposition to the Labour in the next elections, despite the growth in popularity of far-right parties Restore Britain and Reform UK. She said her party was ready to govern and had learned from its mistakes. The Conservatives were in power for 14 years, but their popularity had waned and they were beleaguered by internecine



Kemi Badenoch

battles, cycling through five Prime Ministers over these years, until they lost to the Labour in 2024. In her speech, Ms. Badenoch also pushed back against uniting with parties on the Right. Referring to the defection of a number of MPs to

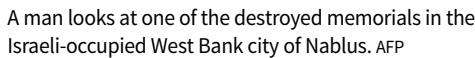
Reform since the 2024 general election, Ms. Badenoch said, the Tories had had an “export boom” of “drama queens”. Among those who had defected was former Conservative Home Secretary Suella Braverman, who is of Indian descent. Ms. Badenoch also appealed to former Tory voters who had shifted their allegiance to Reform, saying she wanted them to “come back home”. “So, to those who say unite the right, we are not uniting with that,” she said. The Tory chief, who is of Nigerian descent, took a dig at those on the far-right who had, in recent public

discourse, taken a view that Englishness was an ethnicity rather than a nationality. “I don’t want to live in a country run by people who threaten journalists, who call veterans traitors, and debate whether my mixed-race children are English,” she said. Commenting on the cost of servicing the public debt, Ms. Badenoch said the U.K. was “running out of money”. She announced her party had identified savings, promised cuts to inheritance tax, reforming the welfare system, and backed a third runway for Heathrow airport.

Iran has ‘lost complete control’ of strait: Rubio

Agence France-Presse
ATHENS

Iran has “lost complete control” of the Strait of Hormuz, U.S. Secretary of State Marco Rubio said on Wednesday, adding that Tehran’s economy was “in total and complete free fall”. “The Straits of Hormuz are open. There’s almost as much oil flowing out now as there was before this conflict began. So they’ve lost complete control of the Straits,” Mr. Rubio told presspersons.



Agence France-Presse
RAMALLAH

Israeli troops also raided the West Bank city of Nablus, “destroyed five memorials to martyrs in various parts of the city” and arrested scores of residents, deputy mayor Iyad Bakeer told AFP.

During a confrontation between dozens of Palestinians and Israeli settlers, “a security personnel member and an additional Israeli civilian opened fire” at the scene, the military said.

Associated Press
KUALA LUMPUR

Min Aung Hlaing greets a diplomat before his departure to Malaysia at the Naypyitaw international airport on Wednesday. AP

The Rohingya question



before his departure to Malaysia for a two-day visit on Wednesday. AP

The U.N. high commissioner for refugees and rights groups have criticised the repatriations, saying the security and humanitarian situation in parts of Myanmar remains volatile and returnees could face persecution and forced military

There are about 126,000 Rohingya in Malaysia and they face public hostility due to their increasing numbers and related concerns.

Former Bangladesh Foreign Secretary Farooq Sobhan said absence of an arbitration clause in the treaty was a problem. GETTY IMAGES

Loud call: Supporters of jailed former Prime Minister Imran Khan take part in a march demanding his release in Khyber district of Khyber Pakhtunkhwa province on Wednesday. Khan maintains the corruption charges against him are politically motivated. AFP

A photograph of a long, multi-span bridge crossing a wide river. The sun is low on the horizon, creating a warm, golden glow and reflecting on the water. The bridge has many piers and spans, stretching far into the distance. The sky is a mix of orange and blue.

'Promise' of dam

Earlier, former Foreign Secretary Farooq Sobhan, who had negotiated the treaty during the first prime ministerial tenure of Sheikh Hasina in 1996, said that the absence of an arbitration clause is a problem for the treaty. Speaking to *The Hindu*, Mr. Sobhan further said that there are unfulfilled promises of India related to the Ganga Water Treaty that will have to be revisited. "India had promised to build a barrage for Padma (Ganga) in the Bangladeshi territory at that time, but it was not

Bangladesh river expert

followed up. That was the quid pro quo for not including the arbitration clause into the treaty. But that barrage was not built," said Mr. Sobhan, informing that Bangladesh in the 1990s carried out surveys regarding building a barrage to store Padma's waters but did not receive the help. Discussions on the renewal of the Ganga Water Treaty has been ongoing in both India and Bangladesh though important technical consultations are yet to be held ahead of the expiry date of December this year.

Earlier Janata Dal (United) MP Sanjay Jha had called on the Government of India not to renew the Ganga Water Treaty saying that

the treaty with Bangladesh had "negatively impacted" Bihar.

Subsequently, External Affairs Minister S. Jaishankar had written to Mr. Jha on August 28, "We fully understand your concerns regarding the Ganga Water Treaty. I would like to bring to your attention that under the leadership of the Jal Shakti Ministry, inter-ministerial consultation involving relevant stakeholders have taken place to ensure broad-based consultation on the future of the treaty."

(The Correspondent was in Dhaka as a guest of Centre for Governance Studies to take part in the Bay of Bengal Conversation.)

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(The Correspondent was in Dhaka as a guest of Centre for Governance Studies to take part in the Bay of Bengal Conversation.)

+

The journey from a promising partnership to a world-class combination

For Indian table tennis, Manush and Diya's was the fourth medal at the Asian Games and ensured that the sport had a podium finish for a third consecutive time

Amol Karhadkar

For four days in early September, Manush Shah travelled to Mumbai, the hometown of his mixed doubles partner Diya Chitale for a relatively simple job. Train. There were no selection meetings to worry about, no administrative developments to follow, no uncertainty over who would be around the Indian table tennis team. In Mumbai, the pair could concentrate on the one thing that had brought them together in the first place – making their partnership work. Those four days would prove valuable when they eventually arrived in Aichi-Nagoya. The sixth-seeded Indian pair went on to win a bronze medal at the Asian Games, beating Hong Kong's third-seeded Wong Chun Ting and Doo Hoi Kem in the quarterfinals before losing to eventual silver medallists Wong Chuqin and Sun Yingsha of China in the semifinals.

Significant achievement For Indian table tennis, the medal was significant. It was the fourth at the Asian Games and ensured that the sport had a podium finish at a third successive edition of the continental extravaganza. For Manush and Diya, though, the bronze represented something more personal. It was the reward for a

partnership that had steadily climbed the international ladder and, in the process, had learnt to complement two very different games. It was also an affirmation that, amid a turbulent build-up, they had managed to keep the noise away from the table. When Diya spoke about going into her second Asian Games, she did not need to be reminded of the difference between a regular international tournament and a multi-sport event. Her first Asian Games, in Hangzhou three years ago, had given her that perspective. "Going into my second Asian Games, I think the first one gave me a lot of experience and exposure," Diya told *The Hindu* before leaving for Japan. "Representing the country at a multi-sport event is a very different feeling. It was a great experience in 2023, and I wanted to carry that experience forward." But there was a difference this time. The expectations were higher. Diya and Manush were no longer simply an emerging combination hoping to make an impression. They had become one of India's principal medal contenders, their progress reflected by a place among the world's top-eight pairs at the 2025 WTT Finals, the season-ending event reserved for the leading performers of the year. "We have been doing really well in doubles," Diya had said ahead of the Games. "Me and Manush have been doing really, really well for the last two or three years. When we started, our graph has gone up a lot." That graph eventually took them to an Asian Games podium. The bronze did not arrive out of nowhere. Over the preceding seasons, the pair had learnt the demands of international mixed doubles, where the rhythm and speed of a rally can differ considerably from men's doubles.

Breaking it down Manush described the distinction in simple terms. "In men's doubles, you expect power from the opponents. The ball really travels and you expect good quality, so you don't have to manage the front-and-back movement as much," he said. "In mixed doubles, it is the opposite. The front-and-back movement becomes really important because the woman on the opposing pair may not be as powerful. They try to play quickly, so the ball can be a little slower and you have to make faster adjustments with your footwork." That difference requires more than just technical ability. It requires trust. "In mixed doubles, Diya is the one with the control and I try to finish the point," Manush said. "If this works out, then we are already one step ahead of the opponent. That is what the goal is all about in doubles." The quarterfinal against Hong Kong was evidence of that equation working when it mattered. India's table tennis contingent had not arrived at Aichi-Nagoya without precedent. In 2018, the men's team won a historic bronze and Sharath Kamal and Manika Batra added another bronze in mixed doubles. In

Hangzhou, Ayhika Mukherjee and Sutirtha Mukherjee produced a surprise run to the women's doubles bronze. Manush and Diya's medal therefore extended the sequence of Indian table tennis appearing on the Asian Games podium. Yet it carried a different weight. Unlike the Hangzhou women's doubles bronze, which came as a surprise, this was a medal India had begun to expect from the pair. Their qualification for the WTT Finals in 2025 had placed them among the world's leading combinations, while their performances over the preceding couple of seasons had made them a credible medal proposition. "Since two or three years, we have been doing really well," Diya had said. "We understand each other's game better now. We know each other's strengths and weaknesses." That understanding had been tested against the world's best. "We have played a lot of top pairs over the years," she said. "We have beaten a top Japanese pair and qualified for the WTT Finals, where the top eight pairs in the world play. All these experiences put together have helped us reach where we are today." The Asian Games simply provided the biggest stage yet on which that accumulated experience had to translate into a result. And it did. The achievement becomes more significant when the build-up to the Asian Games is considered. Indian table tennis spent much of the preceding months dealing with issues away from the playing arena. The selection controversy surrounding Manika Batra had cast a shadow over the process after she was left out of the Asian Games squad for failing to meet the prescribed selection criteria. The episode led to questions about the transparency of the selection system and public exchanges between the paddler and the federation. Then, in August, the Sports Ministry suspended the recognition of the Table Tennis Federation of India as the National Sports Federation for table tennis, citing a series of administrative and governance issues. The turmoil had consequences beyond the boardroom. Massimo Costantini's tenure as India's foreign expert had expired on May 15, and the uncertainty surrounding the federation meant his continuation with the national set-up was delayed. The Italian eventually joined the Indian contingent in Japan only a week before the Asian Games. Against that backdrop, Manush and Diya had little choice but to concentrate on what they could control.

Rising expectations There was no luxury of an extended camp dedicated exclusively to the mixed doubles combination. The international calendar rarely allows it. But the partnership had already developed enough understanding to make those sessions count. Diya was aware before the Games that expectations would follow them. The pair's rise had ensured that. "Pressure is always going to be there," she had said. "There will always be some expectations and some pressure. But what is important is that we gave our best and are happy with the way it

progressed." That attitude became particularly relevant in the quarterfinal. A defeat would have meant another near-miss for Indian table tennis. A victory would guarantee at least a bronze. Manush and Diya delivered. The win over Wong and Doo, seeded third, confirmed the medal and effectively transformed their status from contenders to medallists. The bronze was secure. While Manush has come a long way since starting to train under Shailesh Gosain's watchful eyes in Vadodra, Diya has been coached by Sachin Shetty ever since she took up the sport more than a decade and a half ago. Since their junior days, Olympic Gold Quest has been supporting the duo's journey towards excellence in the international circuit. Government support has also reduced some of the financial pressure on athletes and their families. "With so many government schemes, the Government helps a lot with the TOPS scheme," Diya said. "Of course, that also relieves the financial pressure on the parents." That support becomes especially relevant when an athlete is required to travel extensively, train continuously and compete against the world's best. By the time Diya and Manush stepped onto the Asian Games arena, they were carrying the work of that entire ecosystem with them. More than just a bronze. The significance of the medal extends beyond the result of one quarterfinal and one semifinal.

Bigger message It means India has now won table tennis medals at three consecutive Asian Games. It means the country has a established mixed doubles combination capable of competing with the best in Asia. And it confirms that Manush and Diya's journey from promising partnership to world-class combination has been real. Their qualification for the 2025 WTT Finals had already indicated where they belonged. The Asian Games provided a different kind of test – one where the draw, the occasion and the weight of expectations all mattered. They responded by beating the third seeds and securing India's only table tennis medal at the Games. The loss to the Chinese pair in the semifinal did not diminish what had been achieved. If anything, it reinforced the progression. Three years earlier, Diya had entered her first Asian Games looking for experience and exposure while Manush had endured the disappointment of being one point away from a medal in men's doubles. This time they went for a medal. "We went into the Asian Games aiming for a medal," Diya said. "And we are thrilled that we have achieved the objective and have brought that medal home".

THE GIST

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